

Grammatically citing your sources via “say”-complementation

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Abstract

Across the world’s languages, one of the most common clausal complementation strategies involves a form of the verb “say.” Most research in this area assumes “say” to be equivalent to the English complementizer “that.” The present paper argues that an element in Lubukusu (Bantu, Kenya) that was formerly treated as an agreeing complementizer is actually a stative verb meaning “say.” This “say” predicate is the head of a clausal adjunct that merges at the VP level of the matrix clause, reasonably mimicking a complementizer. However, we demonstrate a number of reasons to think it is a verb. As a consequence of this analysis, an otherwise complex agreement system is reduced to run-of-the-mill subject-verb agreement both within the matrix clause and within a clausal adjunct. A central part of the argument is claiming that the verb “say” introduces two arguments, a *SOURCE* argument and a *COMMUNICATED CONTENT* argument; this argument structure explains a broad range of properties of “say” cross-linguistically and correctly predicts a range of otherwise unexpected patterns in Lubukusu. If correct, this proposal advances our understanding of complementation structures and solves a standing agreement puzzle. We introduce a broad range of new Lubukusu patterns relevant to the argument structure of this verbal element, with implications for complementation, multiple-verb constructions, and agreement. In the course of the argument, we also address common objections to this kind of approach by showing that “say” in English has a number of previously under-appreciated properties that parallel the Lubukusu facts. We conclude with some brief comments on the implications for a theory of selection.

1 Introduction

1.1 Revisiting Lubukusu *AGR-li*

This paper revisits clausal complementation structures in Lubukusu (Bantu, Kenya). Lubukusu has an agreeing lexical item (*AGR-li*) that introduces apparent complement clauses.¹

- (1) Alfredi ne nase khw-a-lom-a khu-li ba-keni b-ool-ile.
1Alfred and I 1PL.SM-PST-speak-FV 1PL.SM-SAY 2-guests 2SM-arrive-PFV
‘Alfred and I said that the guests arrived.’ (Diercks 2010, 298, with glosses adjusted)

These constructions were initially discussed by Diercks (2010, 2013), with subsequent re-analyses appearing in Carstens (2016), Diercks et al. (2020), Ke (2023), and Hanson (2025). All of this previous work treated the agreeing element *-li* (henceforth *AGR-li*) as a prototypical complementizer that heads a CP complement of the matrix verb, with phi-agreement as the exceptional and theoretically intriguing property. We instead argue in favor of an analysis that makes two main claims: 1) *AGR-li* is a verb, and 2) *AGR-li* heads an adjunct to the matrix verb phrase, with a subject that is typically *pro*, as sketched in (2b).²

- (2) a. Alfred and I say *AGR-li* guests arrived.
b. [[Alfred and I]_i [vP [VP speak (something)] [XP *pro*_i SAY [guests arrived]]]]

This verbal analysis proposes a particular argument structure for “say” predicates: “say” introduces a *COMMUNICATED CONTENT* argument as its complement, and a *SOURCE* argument that designates the source of the communicated content.

¹Our glossing for Lubukusu follows the traditional Bantuist tradition. Cardinal numbers represent noun classes, with odd numbers being the singular noun class and the immediately ascendant even number being the plural of that noun class (e.g. class 2 is the plural of class 1). For example, 1SM is the class 1 subject marker. Person-marking is glossed as a cardinal number paired with number marking. So 1PL.SM is the first person plural subject marker. FV stands for ‘final vowel,’ which is a typically obligatory mood marker on the end of verb forms. Other glossing follows the Leipzig Glossing Rules. All data in this paper represent the language knowledge and judgments of the second author, who is a native speaker of Lubukusu and who originates from Bungoma North region of Bungoma County of western Kenya.

²This shares some properties with the analysis in Diercks (2010, 2013), in contrast to the approaches in Carstens (2016) and Diercks et al. (2020), but differs from all of them in central ways.

- (3) Argument structure of ‘say’
[SOURCE say [COMMUNICATED CONTENT]]

Part of why the agreement configuration of *AGR-li* is so intriguing is that the pervasive pattern is for agreement on *AGR-li* to match the features of the matrix subject, a highly atypical agreement configuration in the Minimalist model wherein an agreeing head searches its complement for a goal (cf. Chomsky 2001, Baker 2008, Diercks 2013, Carstens 2016, Ke 2023, among others). And a robust literature on similar agreeing complementizer-like elements has emerged in recent years, making a precise analysis of these elements a robust concern (Diercks and Rao, 2019; Driemel and Kouneli, 2025; Idiatov, 2010; Torrence, 2016; Kawasha, 2007; Letsholo and Safir, 2019; Baker, 2008, 2024; Burukina, 2023).

The previous Agree-centric analyses of *AGR-li* crucially presupposed a rigid matrix-subject orientation of agreement on *AGR-li*, and proposed syntax-centric mechanisms for what controls agreement on *AGR-li*. In contrast, we show that *AGR-li* agrees like a typical predicate does with its subject, and its subject is determined according to its SOURCE thematic role (whether or not it is coreferent with the matrix subject). Through fine-grained pragmatic control of examples, we show a number of agreement configurations that were previously thought to be impossible are in fact grammatical in Lubukusu. Some of this involves introduction of novel diagnostics, but we also show that some patterns that were previously thought to be ungrammatical are in fact only infelicitous (i.e. there are pragmatic contexts where those patterns become acceptable). We also show that appropriate control of the pragmatic contexts also allows for a root-clause use of this “say” predicate. In this way, our work proposes that Lubukusu *AGR-li* ought to be considered in the rich and growing literature on say-complementation (Kratzer, 2016; Major and Stockwell, 2021; Major and Torrence, 2020; Major, 2021; Driemel and Kouneli, 2025; Ye, 2025; Özyıldız and Uegaki, 2024) and these conclusions are also deeply relevant to the longstanding and ongoing investigation into the nature of clausal complementation in general.

This account also provides the first explanation for a range of interpretive effects of *AGR-li*, which were first reported by Diercks (2013). Neither that work nor any of the subsequent work attempted to explain these facts; we propose that these interpretive effects are in fact central to understanding *AGR-li*.

1.2 *AGR-li* is a verb

This option of treating say-based complementizer-like elements as verbs that participate in a serial verb construction has been entertained before, but has been largely dismissed based on a number of overarching objections (see, among others, discussions in Baker 2024).

- (4) Objections to a verbal analysis of Lubukusu *AGR-li*:
- Why doesn’t *AGR-li* always/obviously mean “say”? It can occur with (for example) verbs of receptive communication (e.g. *hear*) and stative attitude predicates (e.g. *know*).
 - Why can’t *AGR-li* be modified like verbs typically can be?
 - How can *AGR-li* agree with inanimate subjects, which cannot be literal say-ers?

Our answer to all of these questions is effectively that these properties are, in fact, the precise properties of “say” verbs cross-linguistically. So while the informal prototypical conception of “say” (i.e. “saying” an overt verbal utterance) is at odds with these properties of *AGR-li*, a more precise description of the properties of “say” verbs generally shows that *AGR-li* is in fact a fairly unremarkable instance of a “say”-predicate (Grimshaw, 2015; Major and Stockwell, 2021; Major, 2021; Kratzer, 2022). With respect to (4a), we demonstrate that “say” often does not encode an utterance event – as a matter of fact, in following with Major and Stockwell (2021) and Major (2021), we argue that “say” has a stative core that doesn’t require an explicit speech event, as shown in (5).

- (5) It says a lot that you’re reading this paper.

With respect to (4b), we suggest that the types of modification and arguments that can be introduced (e.g. a Goal) are determined by the particular use of “say.” In (5), it is unsurprising that manner modification and a Goal are not permitted: it is a stative predicate, in this instance, not eventive. With respect to (4c), we show that this is not a concern because certain inanimate DPs are regularly permitted as subjects of “saying,” e.g. *rumor* in (6).

- (6) During her conversation with Bill Gates on Netflix’s series What’s Next? The Future, Gaga shared her experience with the rumor. “When I was in my early 20s, **there was a rumor saying I was a man**,” she explained. (from <https://evrimagaci.org/tpg/lady-gaga-laughs-off-rumors-she-was-born-male-40753>)

So, the lesson will be that “say” (even in English) is more abstract and flexible than is commonly assumed, and therefore we ought not be surprised that “say” verbs in complementation contexts (like *AGR-li*) show similar properties.

1.3 *AGR-li* clauses are adjunct clauses

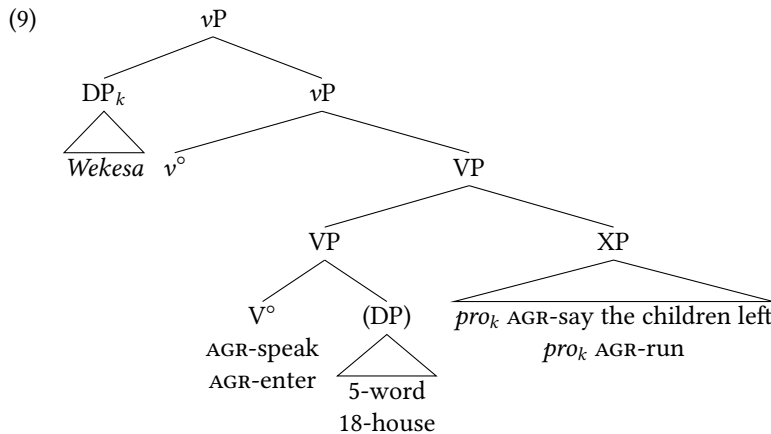
The second main claim of our work is that *AGR-li* clauses are adjuncts in multiple-verb constructions, and not complements of matrix predicates. Lubukusu has a type of manner adjunct clause that is reminiscent of Turkic converbs, SVCs, or English *-ing* clauses that involve an agreeing predicate directly modifying the matrix VP (Major, 2021, 2024; Privoznov, 2022). So the *AGR-li* analysis in (2b) is not specific to complementation structures. Instead, it is the same grammatical mechanism used more generally in manner adjunct clauses, such as (7):

- (7) Wekesa a-kha- engil-e mu-nju a- tim-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-FUT-enter-FUT 18-house 1SM-run-FV
 ‘Wekesa will enter the house running.’

In cases like (7), the matrix verb “enter” hosts both a subject marker (*a*) and tense marker (*-kha-*), while the manner modifying clause is truncated, where “run” only hosts a subject marker. This clause indicates the manner (i.e. “enter the house *running*”). This is a similar morphological pattern to the one observed in *AGR-li* constructions like (8); we will propose that these constructions receive parallel analyses.

- (8) Wekesa a-a- lom-a (li-khuwa) a- li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-say-FV 5-word 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa spoke (the word) saying that the children left.’
 idiomatically: ‘Wekesa said that the children left.’

Notice that there is a single tense marker, which occurs on the matrix verb *-lom-* “speak,” which is preceded by a subject marker (SM). The second clause displays *-li*, which we argue to be a predicate, which hosts only a SM, similar to “run” in (7). We propose that the cases in (7) and (8) share the same core syntactic structure, as illustrated in (9).



Therefore, in typical instances of *AGR-li*, it is a verbal element heading an adjunct clause, that introduces two arguments: a *pro* subject (the SOURCE) that is typically coreferent with the matrix subject, and a complement clause that realizes the COMMUNICATED CONTENT.³

³The nature of the empty category (when it occurs) is debateable, heads of adjunct clauses are often analyzed as PRO, and overt DPs may

1.4 Roadmap

Our proposal therefore has two main novel contributions that are logically independent of each other. First, we argue that *AGR-li* is a verb with its own argument structure. Second, we argue that clauses introduced by *AGR-li* are adjuncts, rather than complement clauses.

In §2 we outline reasons from English to think that the argument structure for “say” that is outlined in (3) is reasonable even outside of Lubukusu: the meaning of “say” is abstract beyond a prototypical speaking event. §3 then offers the first sequence of argumentation that *AGR-li* is in fact a verbal element, based mainly on its argument structure and its use as a matrix predicate. §4 moves to the external syntax of *AGR-li* clauses, arguing that they compose with matrix clauses via adjunction and are not selected complement clauses of the matrix verb.

§5 offers a range of novel evidence based on the properties of *SOURCE* arguments wherein *AGR-li* agrees with non-matrix-subjects, in contradiction to all previously-reported patterns. §6 shows that adjunct *saying*-clauses in English show precisely parallel patterns to Lubukusu *AGR-li* patterns, reinforcing the analysis of “say” argument structure that we advance, and the corroborating our analysis in (9). §7 considers some plausible alternative analyses, and §8 concludes.

2 The argument structure of English “say”

AGR-li “say” exhibits a wide distribution in Lubukusu, in many cases not corresponding to the properties of the verbal communication that we typically associate with “saying:” this is why this analysis was not immediately obvious in previous work on the topic. We advocate for treating *AGR-li* as an abstract “say” predicate to offer an explanation for this. As a point of departure, we illustrate that the properties of English “say” are likewise abstract and bear many of the hallmarks of *AGR-li* that we discuss throughout the paper. The point is that the properties of *AGR-li* “say” in Lubukusu are in fact not atypical at all: we illustrate here from English but, as mentioned above, there is a growing literature on say-based complementation that shows parallel properties.

2.1 “say” introduces COMMUNICATED CONTENT

Grimshaw (2015) treats English “say” as the overt realization of a light verb, *SAY*. *SAY* is a transitive predicate on this approach, encoding a dynamic speech event involving an Agent (the speaker), some content (what was said), and often a Goal (the person the speech was directed at). This prototypical use of “say” is provided in (10):

- (10) The teacher said to the students that the exam was easy. (Grimshaw, 2015, 80:2)

In (10), Grimshaw refers to ‘the teacher’ as an Agent, ‘the students’ as a Goal, and the clausal complement ‘that the exam was easy’ as *Linguistic Material*. When one thinks of the verb ‘say,’ this is likely the use of the predicate that first comes to mind. However, Grimshaw (2015) further notes the existence of ‘stative’ say, shown in (11).

- (11) The sign/poster/book/article said that the park was closed.

Grimshaw treats this as a second lexical entry for ‘say,’ which subcategorizes for a Location (‘the sign/poster/book/article’) and *Linguistic Material* (‘that the park was closed’).

On Grimshaw’s approach, *SAY* is present in all verbs of communication; in this work, we focus on overt uses of “say” for the most part, in both English and Lubukusu. Major and Stockwell (2021) expand upon Grimshaw’s work, demonstrating that “say” allows for an agent (12a), a Location (12b), or an expletive subject (12c):

- (12) a. Mom says, “Slow down!”
b. The sign says, “Slow down!” (on it).
c. It says “Slow down!” on the sign.

sometimes appear here as well. McFadden and Sundaresan (2018) argue for reducing *PRO* and *pro* to a single element to explain distributions like this, but this issue goes outside our main concerns here (and is shared by many other similar puzzles, as McFadden and Sundaresan make clear).

In order to account for this, [Major and Stockwell](#) argue for a constructivist approach, by which the ambiguity between types of ‘saying’ derive from properties of the Voice head merged above SAY. Following [Kratzer \(1996\)](#), the authors suggest that (12a) involves an Agentive Voice head, (12b) involves a Holder Voice head, while the expletive is inserted when there is no Voice head (12c). Under this approach, what unifies each instance of “say” is a core that includes the introduction of Linguistic Material, while the VP-external syntax (especially Voice) determines whether “say” encodes an actual utterance or not. In other words, “say” is responsible for introducing Linguistic Material. Moving forward, we will replace the term Linguistic Material with ‘Communicated Content,’ because Linguistic Material is often used to refer explicitly to direct quotation.

2.2 “say” may be stative or eventive

In subsequent work, [Major \(2021, 2024\)](#) expanded on the aforementioned literature, demonstrating that “say” can be stative even with animate subjects. (13) uses a context where “say” is in the simple present tense, but the actual communicative event took place in the past. The simple present/narrative present is known to have a range of interesting properties ([Anand and Tooservandani, 2020](#); [Anand and Toosarvandani, 2022](#)). A full analysis is outside our current purposes; here, we simply use it to illustrate a restriction on “say” to stative uses. In the context in (13) it is no longer possible to introduce manner modification or a Goal argument for “say,” similar to the findings for stative “say” above ([Grimshaw, 2015](#); [Major and Stockwell, 2021](#)).⁴ In this sense, the subject, ‘she,’ behaves much like an attitude holder for stative predicates (13b).⁵

- (13) *Context: I spoke with Katie yesterday for the first time and haven’t spoken with her again.*
- a. She (#cheerfully) says (#to me) that she’ll be attending the conference.
 - b. She says/thinks/believes/knows that she’ll be attending the conference.

As (14) shows, a report of past events using past tense allows for the full range of eventive properties, including manner modification and the presence of a GOAL argument.

- (14) *Context: I spoke with Katie yesterday for the first time and haven’t spoken with her again.*
She (cheerfully) said (to me) that Kayla will be visiting!

So we see that “say” is consistent with a stative use, even with animate subjects. As with most stative vs dynamic alternations, it is not that the past tense forces a dynamic interpretation, but rather that the eventive reading becomes a natural option. Once one introduces a modifier like “up until...,” the stative reading is again favored.

- (15) a. Up until around 1520, people said the earth was flat.
b. Up until 5 minutes ago, Katie said that she’ll be attending the conference.

Neither of the sentences in (15) describe a particular “saying” event, rather, they report a state in which the subjects of “say” were responsible for the information in the COMMUNICATED CONTENT complement of “say.”

2.3 “say” introduces a SOURCE argument

The stative reading of ‘say’ is inherently favored with inanimate subjects, such as (16) below, where the stative reading is obligatory (insofar as we can discern). We refer to this use of “say” in (16) as **inferential “say”**,⁶ which will help us clarify the readings in what follows. In these instances, the speaker of the sentence articulates content that is communicated by the subject of “say,” but that content reflects an inference on the part of the speaker. It is also possible to introduce the EXPERIENCER in many of these cases, as shown below:⁷

⁴A reviewer asks what type of state we are claiming that ‘say’ is. We are treating it as though it is a Kimian state analogous to ‘know’ or ‘believe’. There exist complicating factors, most severely the fact that it is often possible to coerce a speech production reading of ‘say’, an option that is unavailable for ‘know’ or ‘believe’. For present purposes, what matters most is that there is a non-agentive ‘say’ that does not encode a speech articulation event and resists event modifiers, goals, etc.

⁵See [Özyıldız \(2021\)](#) for comprehensive discussion and analysis of dynamic vs. stative ‘think’.

⁶See [Anand et al. \(2017\)](#) for related discussion.

⁷The PP indirect object in (16) is importantly not a GOAL object: the squirrel tracks are not literally uttering words to the speaker of the sentence. Rather, *to me* introduces the EXPERIENCER, the one reaching the relevant inference via their perceptions.

- (16) The squirrel tracks outside Kayla’s office say (to me) that she isn’t adequately disposing of her peanut shells.

In following with [Major \(2021\)](#), we argue that stative “say” does not assign an AGENT theta role, instead assigning a SOURCE theta role. Notice in (16) that the subject *the squirrel tracks* is clearly not an attitude holder; however, it is the speaker’s SOURCE that enables them to (truthfully) utter the COMMUNICATED CONTENT *that she isn’t adequately disposing of her peanut shells*. We assume here a SOURCE thematic role that means something like “the speaker’s source for the reported information,” or perhaps more loosely “to which the speaker attributes responsibility for the reported information.”

In the same vein, we take ‘she’ (referring to Katie) in (13a) to be the SOURCE of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT, as this event description does not treat ‘she’ as an agent, because the speech report entirely lacks a dynamic event. In contrast, in a sentence where “say” is eventive, Katie functions as both an AGENT and also as the SOURCE of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT (17).

- (17) Katie (quietly) said (to me) that she was pregnant.

Inferential “say” can occur in similar circumstances, but clearly rules out manner modification, and the indirect object PP is now interpreted as an EXPERIENCER rather than a GOAL.

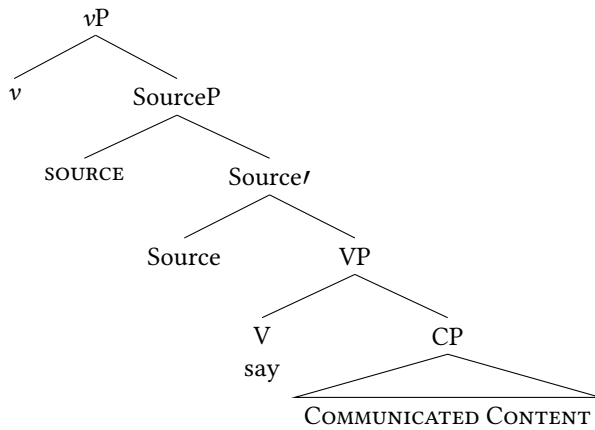
- (18) *Context: Katie is typically a social drinker, but conspicuously has stopped drinking recently.*
Katie’s choice not to drink (#quietly) says (to me) that she is pregnant.

The takeaway lesson for our purposes is that that subject of stative SAY is a SOURCE argument.

2.4 A syntactic implementation for “say” argument structure

Following [Major \(2021\)](#), we assume that the SOURCE is introduced in the lowest VP shell, while the agent is introduced by a higher functional head that embeds the constituent containing the SOURCE, as in (19). Importantly, it is possible to only introduce the SOURCE, which gives rise to the stative reading of ‘say.’ The eventive reading derives from merging the AGENT head, as in (20) ([Hale and Keyser 1993](#); [Mateu 2002](#); [Folli and Harley 2005](#); [Harley 2005](#); [Ramchand 2008](#), among others, building upon previously analyzed lexical conceptual structures: [Jackendoff 1990](#); [Levin and Rappaport Hovav 1998](#)). The analysis in (19) for stative “say” is our structural analysis for Lubukusu *AGR-li*.

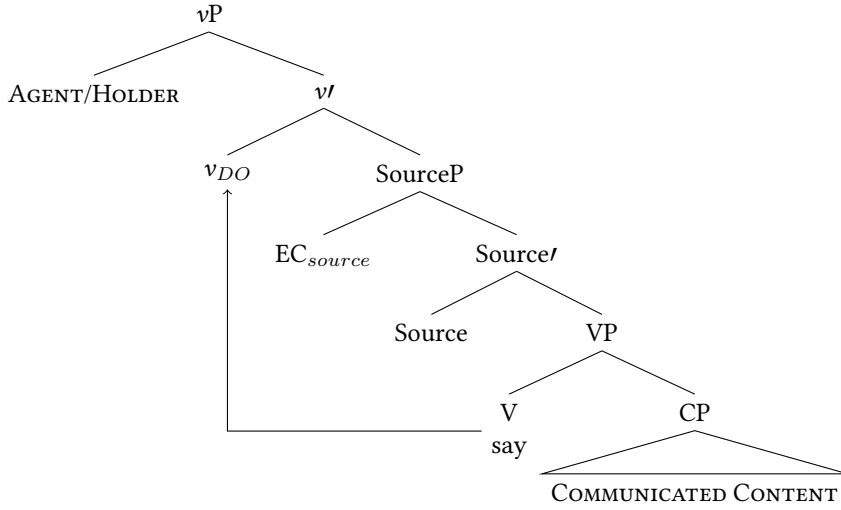
- (19) English stative “say,” also Lubukusu *AGR-li*



(20) shows the structure for eventive “say” (adapted from [Major, 2021](#)). We include this to show how this conceptualization of “say” extends to eventive, matrix uses of “say” in languages where it occurs, but Lubukusu does not utilize this structure for *AGR-li*.⁸

⁸We therefore don’t explore in depth here the nature of the EC in examples like this; it could well be a trace of movement, PRO, or something else: see footnote 3.

(20)



We choose to model this contrast syntactically, where the syntactic head responsible for introducing the agent and eventive semantics embeds a stative core, as opposed to simply assuming two homophonous/separate lexical entries for two instances of “say.” This approach is more compatible with recent literature, which we find promising (Grimshaw, 2015; Major, 2021; Kratzer, 2022), but this is not crucial for present purposes (as far as we can tell).

The main takeaway lesson is that English “say” is not at all restricted to overt verbal acts of speaking, a pattern that appears to be true cross-linguistically as well. We proceed to making the verbal argument for Lubukusu *AGR-li*, but we do return to English in §6 where we show that there are even more parallels between English *saying* and say-complementation crosslinguistically (in Lubukusu and otherwise).

3 AGR-li as a verbal element in Lubukusu

We argue here that *AGR-li* in Lubukusu is a “say” predicate with the same properties that we just established for English, and not a complementizer as previously assumed.

3.1 Predictions

(21) sketches some characteristic grammatical properties of complementizers vs. verbs.

(21) Property	Complementizers	Verbs
Express the core predicate of an eventuality	✗	✓
Introduce their own arguments	✗	✓
Participate in multiple verb constructions	✗	✓
Part of extended functional projections of verb phrases	✓	✗
serve the grammatical function of introducing an embedded clause	✓	✓

We are disinclined to posit formal definitions of these grammatical categories, an exercise that is well known to be somewhat fraught. Our intention, rather, is to demonstrate that *AGR-li* in Lubukusu shares properties with canonical verbs (and diverges from the properties of canonical complementizers) in ways that make a verbal analysis desirable on multiple levels.⁹ Crucially, none of the predictions of the verbal analysis of *AGR-li* in (22) are predicted by an analysis of *AGR-li* as a complementizer.

⁹One could perhaps argue that we should allow functional elements like clause-subordinators that are part of extended projections to behave as predicates introducing arguments: this is the precise strategy of Burukina (2023). If grammatical categories are all emergent, perhaps a language can evolve a category that shares all these properties. We don’t actually find that kind of stance overly problematic, and none of our argumentation is designed to argue against that kind of intermediate/emergent approach to categories. The main point is that this apparent complementizer (*AGR-li*) displays a wide variety of verb-like properties.

(22) Predictions of a verbal analysis of Lubukusu *AGR-li*

1. *AGR-li* behaves like a predicate (a *saying* eventuality) introducing two arguments (SOURCE and COMMUNICATED CONTENT). This leads to more precise predictions:
 - *AGR-li* can occur as a matrix verb (§3.2)
 - *AGR-li*'s subject (the target of its agreement) can track the source of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT. (§3.4, §5)
 - In some contexts the matrix subject may in fact be an undesirable (or impossible) controller of agreement on *AGR-li* (§5)
2. Since *AGR-li* selects for COMMUNICATED CONTENT (and matrix predicates do not), we expect to see selectional differences between matrix predicates and *AGR-li* (§3.3, §4.1)
3. *AGR-li* can occur in unselected embedding environments (does not need to head a complement clause) (§4.2)

In addition to core predictions like these in (22), we present a range of evidence throughout that makes a complementizer analysis of *AGR-li* increasingly implausible. So while in many instances it might be possible to imbue complementizers with the relevant properties/characteristics (by stipulation), we show that the evidence is consistently aligned with how we expect verbs to behave, and is consistently misaligned with typical properties of complementizers. So in addition to a variety of core predictions of previous accounts of *AGR-li* failing to be upheld, a preponderance of the evidence creates a powerful circumstantial case for the verbal analysis that we present.

3.2 *AGR-li* as a matrix predicate

An immediate reason for thinking that *AGR-li* is a verbal predicate is that it can be used as the main predicate in the matrix clause, as shown in (23). *-li* “say” can function as the sole predicate of sentence, which can occur with an external argument that is animate (23a) or inanimate (23b).¹⁰ In these contexts, we analyze *AGR-li* as a verb selecting for a CP complement, as we showed in (19) above.

- (23) a. Wekesa a-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV
 ‘Wekesa says that the children left.’
 b. e-barua e-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 9-letter 9SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV
 ‘The letter says the children left.’

Sentences like those in (23) aren’t always entirely natural out of the blue, however. Similar to English generic present tense “says”, using *AGR-li* presupposes a communicative event and it must be the case that the actual communicative act not be pertinent to the present discourse where sentences like those in (23) are uttered. If reference to the actual utterance event is made by the discourse context, a manner predicate (e.g. *-lom-* “speak/tell”) is required.

- (24) Q: w-a-ch-a mw-i-duka khubela si(ina)?
 2SG.SM-PST-go-FV 18-9-bodega reason 7what
 ‘Why did you go to the store?’
 A: Nafula #(a-lom-a) a-li eny-a ka-ma-beele.
 1Nafula 1SM.PST-speak-FV 1SM-SAY 1SM.PST.want-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘Nafula said that she wants milk.’
 proposed literal meaning: ‘Nafula said (something)/spoke, saying that she wants milk.’

If one accepts the analysis of English eventive “say” in (20), this distinction falls out quite naturally. English allows for raising from the head of SourceP to *v*, allowing for a single instance of the verb “say” to carry out the functions

¹⁰Kawasha (2007) reported similar behaviors from the so-called agreeing complementizers analyzed there, as does the work on Kipsigis say-complementation (Diercks and Rao, 2019; Driemel and Kouneli, 2025).

of stative “say” and eventive “say” (including introduction of the SOURCE and the AGENT). This opens the door for a language like Lubukusu to lexicalize both the stative component and the activity component independently, using a modification structure to derive the interpretation.¹¹

Put in other words, we are claiming that *AGR-li* is the predicate “say” that is embedded within a clausal adjunct that modifies the matrix VP, as we suggest for (24A).

3.3 *AGR-li* introduces COMMUNICATED CONTENT

A core property of English “say” is that it introduces COMMUNICATED CONTENT. We take COMMUNICATED CONTENT to encompass direct quotation, propositional content, or abstract nominals that can stand in for direct quotation/propositional content. For Lubukusu, that selection of COMMUNICATED CONTENT is a unique property of *AGR-li* within the language. Matrix predicates do not introduce clausal complements with communicated content, only *AGR-li* does.

(25) demonstrates that only *-li* is able to take a clausal complement. This is true both when it occurs as a main verb and also when it combines with another verb like *-lom-* ‘say/tell/speak’ or *-yokel-* ‘scream.’ These clauses can either be composed of propositional content or utterances/direct quotation. Thus we argue that *-li* is actually responsible for introducing clauses, which differentiates *-li* from predicates that it co-occurs with.^{12,13}

- (25) a. Watulo a-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Watulo 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Watulo says that the children left.’
 ‘Watulo says “The children left.”’
 b. Watulo a-a-loma *(a-li) ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Watulo 1SM-PST-say-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Watulo said that the children left.’
 ‘Watulo said “The children left.”’
 c. Watulo a-n-jokel-el-a *(a-li) ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Watulo 1SM.PST-1SG.OM-scream-APPL-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Watulo screamed to me, saying the children left.’
 ‘Watulo screamed to me, saying, “The children left.”’

English has a sophisticated taxonomy of nominals that combine with clause-taking predicates, but the situation is more straightforward in Lubukusu. *-li*, which corresponds to SAY, simply cannot take a nominal complement, aside from *siina* ‘what,’ whose categorical status is not straightforward anyway (as we discuss in §4.1). Predicates that combine with *-li*, however, are able to combine with nominal arguments in addition to combining with *-li* depending on valency/subcategorization. For instance, *-lom-* requires an AGENT and can also take a DP complement, as shown for *bu-beyi* ‘lie’ (26).

- (26) a. *Nafula a-li bu-beyi.
 1Nafula 1SM-say 14-lie
 Intended: ‘Nafula says the lie.’

¹¹This is highly reminiscent of the contrast between verb and satellite framed languages (Talmy, 1985), separating languages that use ‘satellites’ of the main verb in multiple-verb constructions (e.g. Mandarin, Ewe, Lubukusu) and those that use particles (e.g. English). Folli and Harley (2020) offer an analysis that correlates Talmy’s generalization with the ability for Res(ult) to undergo a movement that quite naturally parallels the arguments we make for “say” in English.

¹²In earlier work on this issue, there was not careful control of whether a predicate/circumstance was specifically introducing COMMUNICATED CONTENT or not (vs. just complement clauses more generally), so (for example) Diercks (2010) lists a null complementizer as simply another option alongside *AGR-li*.

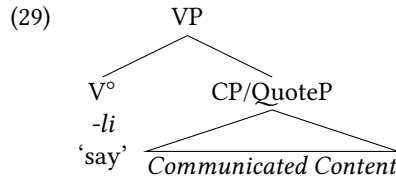
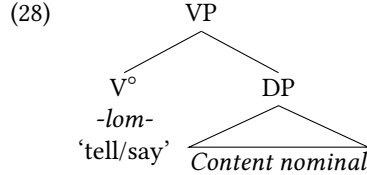
¹³The only other element that introduces finite *that*-type complement clauses in the variety of Lubukusu reported in this paper is *bali*, which is unable to introduce direct speech. Some Lubukusu speakers in the Bungoma region allow use of the complementizer element *mbo* similar to how the second author of this paper uses *bali*; we omit *mbo* as it is not part of the second author’s grammar, but it is to be determined the degree to which the new data reported here are also true for *mbo* speakers, or not.

- b. Nafula a-lom-a bu-beyi.
 1Nafula 1SM.PST-speak-FV 14-lie
 ‘Nafula spoke/said the lie.’
- c. *Nafula a-lom-a a-li bu-beyi.
 1Nafula 1SM.PST-speak-FV 1SM-say 14-lie
 ‘Nafula spoke/said the lie.’¹⁴

In fact, even nominals that arguably stand in for communicated content (like the words-NP *kamakhuya* ‘words’) cannot be introduced by *AGR-li*.¹⁵

- (27) a. *Nafula a-li ka-ma-khuwa.
 1Nafula 1SM-say 6-6-words
 Intended: ‘Nafula says words.’
- b. Nafula a-lom-a ka-ma-khuwa.
 1Nafula 1SM.PST-speak-FV 6-6-words
 ‘Nafula spoke/said words.’
- c. *Nafula a-lom-a a-li ka-ma-khuwa.
 1Nafula 1SM.PST-speak-FV 1SM-say 6-6-words
 Intended: ‘Nafula said words.’

The selectional properties of matrix lexical predicates (e.g. communication and attitude verbs) are distinct from that of *AGR-li*. Communication and attitude verbs vary in valency and can combine with nominal arguments (or not) accordingly. *AGR-li*, on the other hand, combines with only clauses. This contrast is provided in (28) and (29) below:



3.4 *AGR-li* introduces a SOURCE

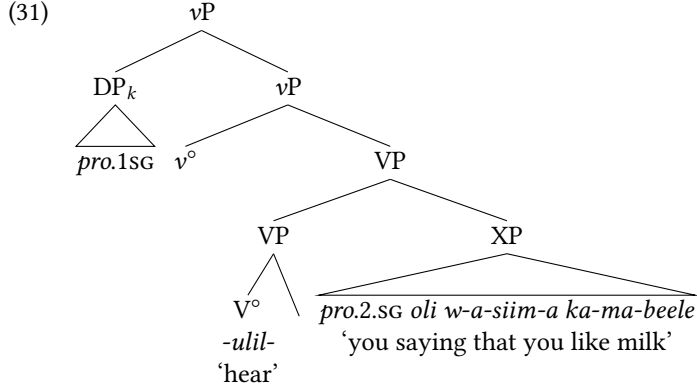
Recall from §2 that we take English “say” to always introduce a SOURCE argument. §3.2 demonstrated that as a matrix verb, *AGR-li* introduces a subject. We suggest that this is always the case (even in embedded contexts) and that this subject is a SOURCE. The phi-features of the SOURCE controls agreement on *AGR-li*. We will elaborate in §5, but to preview these results, we report a range of patterns where the agreement on *AGR-li* is controlled by the source of the reported information, as in (30).¹⁶

¹⁴This is grammatical with the meaning *Nafula said that it is a lie*, in which case *-li* functions as the copula in an impersonal construction.

¹⁵Reviewers rightfully wonder whether *AGR-li* can appear with nominals in examples like “Nafula said hello” or “Nafula said this.” But Lubukusu doesn’t have a nominal greeting word and doesn’t use demonstratives anaphorically for clausal material, so those analogs aren’t available.

¹⁶This is a key empirical departure from previous work on *AGR-li*; we discuss in §5.

- (30) N-a-ulil-a o- li w-a-siim-a ka-ma-beele.
 1SG.SM-PST-hear-FV 2SG-SAY 2SG.SM-PST-like-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘I heard (you saying) that you like milk.’
 (source = addressee: context must make this clear for sentence to be acceptable)



Multiple reviewers inquired about why, if *AGR-li* is a verbal element, we don’t see an overt subject in its embedded uses, especially when the *SOURCE* subject of *AGR-li* is distinct from the matrix subject. In fact, it is possible for there to be an overt (distinct) subject of the *AGR-li* clause itself.

- (32) N-a-ulil-a ewe o- li w-a-siim-a ka-ma-beele.
 1SG.SM-PST-hear-FV 2SG 2SG.SM-SAY 2SG.SM-PST-like-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘I heard (you saying) that you like milk.’
 (source = addressee: context must make this clear for sentence to be acceptable)

- (33) *Context: Nafula and Wafula have been wondering for a while whether the children (Nafula’s younger siblings) will like Wafula. Wafula is a potential husband for Nafula and so everyone wants the children of the family to accept him. So Nafula takes the children out for a special day in town to talk to them about it, after which Nafula was to report the children’s feelings to their parents. Upon returning, a family member could say:*

ba-b-ebusi ba-a-ulil-a (li-khuwa) Nafula a-li ba-ba-ana ba-siim-a Wafula.
 2-2-parents 2SM-PST-hear-FV 5-word 1Nafula 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2-SM-like-FV 1Wafula

‘The parents heard the news (Nafula saying) that the children like Wafula.’

As the example above suggests, however, for sentences like these to sound natural there must be careful control of the pragmatic context. We comment in §5.7 as to the likely reasons why this is the case (i.e. why sentences like (33) are not pervasive). At present, however, we restrict our commentary to the observation that this is possible, suggesting that *AGR-li* is in fact a verbal predicate with its own argument structure and not merely a complementizer.¹⁷

3.5 Lubukusu *AGR-li* as defective stative “say” predicate

There are of course reasons why it was not previously obvious that *AGR-li* is a verbal element: *AGR-li* is a defective verb in a variety of ways. One property of *AGR-li* that distinguishes it from other verbs is its inability to inflect for tense/aspect/mood: more on this below. *AGR-li* also doesn’t display the typical morphological form of a verb: most regular verbs in Lubukusu, as in other Bantu languages, morphologically end with the final vowel, which is *-a* in indicative sentences.¹⁸ A number of typical verbal derivation/inflection does not apply to *AGR-li*: passive, applicative, negation, as well as restrictions on its modification. Some of these limitations we attribute to its character as a stative predicate, and it shares with stative uses of “say” in English. Other aspects of this defectivity seem to be particular to *AGR-li*.

¹⁷In Lubukusu, *pro*-drop is strongly preferred when it is possible, especially in embedded contexts.

¹⁸One prominent exception to this in Lubukusu, and elsewhere, is the copula, another commonly defective verb.

Despite there being matrix uses of *AGR-li*, tense is nonetheless unable to be expressed on *AGR-li*; “say” clauses have been shown to be similarly truncated in Avatime (Major, 2021), Ewe (Clements, 1975; Spadine, 2020), Tigrinya (Spadine, 2020), and Hebrew (Landau, 2006b). So it is worth considering the extent to which *AGR-li* clauses are truncated structures. First, root *AGR-li* constructions are not truncated in the C domain. For instance, there is no prohibition on matrix questions in *AGR-li* constructions. Yes/no questions are indicated by intonation, so the segmental material below is identical to the declarative equivalent (34). If we assume that polar questions are formed based on a feature in the CP domain (or perhaps Force), this suggests that the left periphery is present in root *AGR-li* constructions.

- (34) Wekesa a-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a?
 1Wekesa 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Does Wekesa say that the children left?’

Spadine (2020) suggests that there is only one clausal periphery present in similar data in Tigrinya. However, it is possible to embed a question in Lubukusu, suggesting that both the matrix and embedded clause consist of CPs (35).¹⁹

- (35) Wekesa a-li naanu b-a-ch-a?
 1Wekesa 1SM-SAY 2who 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Does Wekesa say who left?’

For Spadine, a truncation analysis offered an explanation for why tense morphology and temporal adverbs are not permitted for ‘say’ clauses. At first glance, the restriction on temporal adverbs seems to hold in Lubukusu, as well. As was shown for Ewe and Tigrinya, ‘yesterday’ is not permitted (36).

- (36) #Likolooba Wekesa a-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 yesterday 1Wekesa 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 Intended: ‘Yesterday, Wekesa said that the children left.’

However, the adverbials ‘now’ and ‘always’ are felicitous, which suggests that the restriction cannot be characterized as a prohibition on temporal adverbs in *AGR-li* constructions, or a restriction on modification at all. Instead, it seems there is a prohibition on past temporal adverbs.

- (37) Luno Wekesa a-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 now 1Wekesa 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Now, Wekesa says that the children left.’
- (38) E-saini buli lw-oosi e-li o-kh-engil-a-mo ta.
 9-sign every 11-all 9SM-SAY 2SG.SM-PROG-enter-FV-18LOC NEG
 ‘The sign always says do not enter.’

We interpret this as evidence that there is tense in these constructions, which is likely present tense. If we take null tense in Lubukusu to share properties with the English present, this data is perhaps not that surprising. Building on the discussion in §2, notice that the same property holds of English ‘says,’ where ‘yesterday’ is not possible, but ‘now’ is.

- (39) a. I saw Katie yesterday - she says/said she will visit next week.
 b. #Yesterday, Katie says she will visit next week.
 c. (I saw Katie yesterday.) Now she says she will visit next week (she changed her plan).

This is yet another instance of *AGR-li* clauses behaving like this particular use of English present tense constructions. While this issue requires more work (as do the semantics of Lubukusu tense/aspect more generally), this at least

¹⁹We interpret this as evidence that there are in fact two CPs in these structures (i.e. *AGR-li* is not a left-peripheral modal element).

begins to help us understand that the stative *-li* “say” predicate may simply be restricted to a present tense usage, albeit one that is highly dependent on its immediate discourse context. To be clear, though, not all the restrictions on Lubukusu *AGR-li* have parallels to English “say,” we simply point out where such parallels do exist.²⁰ If we take the next step in assuming that *AGR-li* is in the present tense, we might expect it to behave like the English cases in (13), where the temporal properties of the simple present in English are determined by the context in which they are embedded. When there is no local tense, the present is interpreted as ‘now’ (at the utterance time). If a reference time is established, the present is interpreted relative to that time. This is precisely what we see when *AGR-li* occurs in embedded contexts. Notice in (40), for instance, that when modifying the matrix VP in the future, it is interpreted in the future.

(40) *Context: A speechwriter explains to the press what the president will say in his speech later:*

O-mw-aami a-la-lom-a a-li ba-a-sikari ba-la-yukh-a e-ngo.
 1-1-leader 1SM-FUT-speak-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-soldiers 2SM-FUT-return-FV 9-home
 ‘The president/leader will say that the soldiers are returning home.’

An argument in the literature against a verbal analysis of apparent “say” complementation has to do with its restrictions against manner modifiers and Goal arguments (cf. Baker 2024, Burukina 2023). Once we consider the possibility that this element is stative “say,” this becomes less surprising, as manner modifiers are not generally compatible with stative verbs (e.g. “# quickly/quietly knew”). First, notice that *AGR-li* is incompatible with manner modification (41).²¹

(41) Wekesa a-li (*kalaa) ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-SAY slowly 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa said (*quietly) that the children left.’

Lexical predicates of communication that combine with *AGR-li* often encode manner of speech; in these instances, manner modification becomes possible:

(42) Wekesa a-a-lom-a (kalaa) a-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-say-FV slowly 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa said quietly that the children left.’

And we saw above in (37) and (38) that even temporal modification of matrix *AGR-li* is possible as long as it is semantically compatible. So we can conclude then that modification of *AGR-li* is possible as long as it is interpretively consistent with a present tense, stative event.²²

As we have argued above, stative “say” does not encode a communicative act. For this reason, a GOAL argument to which the communicative act was directed cannot be introduced unless there is a verb that denotes a communicative event. Under our proposal for *AGR-li*, it corresponds to only stative “say” and thus cannot host applicative morphology (i.e. introduce a Goal):

(43) *Wekesa a-n-li-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-1SG.OM-say-APPL 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 attempted: ‘Wekesa said to me that the children left.’

However, when *AGR-li* combines with another predicate that denotes a communicative event, that predicate can bear applicative morphology and introduce a Goal argument (44):

²⁰One could question why only a single verb (*-li* ‘say’) shows these restrictions. Perhaps offering some credence to the possibility that “say” should be treated as a light verb (Grimshaw, 2015), signs of defectiveness in light verbs are not so uncommon. For instance, the Welsh verb *gwneud* ‘do’ is sensitive to the stativity/eventivity contrast and shows similar inflectional restrictions, but is quite clearly not a simple auxiliary (Rouveret, 2011). Landau (2006b) demonstrates that [n,g,d] ‘say’/‘tell’ in Modern Hebrew is only permitted in future or infinitival forms. Furthermore, if we are on the right track, we might conclude the Ewe and Tigrinya constructions (along with *AGR-li*) are verbs that are defective in much the same way.

²¹No alternative positioning of the manner adverb makes the sentence in (41) acceptable with the manner adverb: *Wekesa ali kalaa ...; *Wekesa kalaa ali ...; *kalaa Wekesa ali ...

²²Our thanks to reviewers and editors for suggesting these diagnostics.

- (44) Wekesa a-a-m-bol-el-a a-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-1SG.OM-say-APPL-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa said to me (i.e. told me) that the children left.’

Despite its matrix verbal usage, *AGR-li* cannot be passivized. Expletive constructions in Lubukusu typically take a class 6 subject marker; (45) is what an impersonal passive of *AGR-li* would look like if it were possible (but it is not).

- (45) *ka-l-w-a babaana ba-a-ch-a
 6SM-say-PASS-FV 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 Attempted: ‘It is said that the children left.’

As with these other properties, this continues to replicate the English facts on the stative present-tense use of “say” that we reported in (13).²³

Another restriction on *AGR-li* is that it cannot be negated, which does not fall out naturally from stative vs eventive properties. English “say” doesn’t have this same restriction, as (47) shows.²⁴

- (46) *E-barua se-e-li ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a ta.
 9-letter NEG-9SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-go-FV NEG
 Attempted: ‘The letter doesn’t say that the children left.’

- (47) The document doesn’t say that a determination has been reached.

Nonetheless, the restriction in (46) is again reminiscent of English use of “say” in the generic present tense context that we have referenced at various points, which shows a similar restriction with respect to negation.

- (48) *I spoke with Katie yesterday for the first time and haven’t spoken with her again.*
 a. She says that Kayla will be visiting!
 b. #She doesn’t say that Kayla will be visiting!

This property in (46) is not tethered to *AGR-li*’s status as a stative predicate, as there is no prohibition on negation of stative predicates more generally. However, given that matrix *AGR-li* presupposes a prior communication event that is responsible for the content that is expressed in the target sentence, negating the *AGR-li* clause would lead to expressing the content of a communicative event that never happened, which is entirely uninformative. We interpret this as roughly equivalent to English (48), where the present tense report of past tense events likewise renders negation infelicitous.

One could potentially argue that these restrictions are signs that this element is not synchronically verbal. In order to do this, one would need to argue that *AGR-li* is a non-verbal predicate that is responsible for introducing COMMUNICATED CONTENT and a SOURCE and can serve as the main predicate of a clause. If this option is preferable to calling *AGR-li* a verb, we are willing to accept this outcome. The same general pattern is found cross-linguistically and the same conclusions should (roughly) apply across the board. For instance, there is a verb of saying in Hebrew, whose root is [n,g,d], which lacks all past and present forms (Landau, 2006a, pp. 47-48). In many African languages (see Güldemann, 2008), the equivalent element is similarly shown to be defective in certain ways – perhaps the most famous case is Ewe *be* “say,” which often occurs without a subject marker. In each of these cases, the verbal ‘say’ predicate is defective in some way, generally in ways that do not extend to many (or perhaps any) other verbs in the these languages. We take these to constitute a class of defective (or light) verbs, but one could call them something else without drastically changing the analysis. The important point here is that they are most plausibly *not* analyzed as prototypical complementizers, which becomes especially important in the remaining sections.

To conclude: *AGR-li* is a verb, but it is a defective verb that is not identical morphologically or syntactically to other verbs. Some of these properties can be explained by analyzing *AGR-li* as strictly a stative predicate, and some

²³We leave the precise reason that stative say cannot be passivized to future research. We suspect it has the same origin as other stative light verbs like “have” and “be,” which similarly cannot undergo passivization (e.g. **A dog was had by Mittie*), **That we should leave is/was said by Sam*.

²⁴Thanks to a reviewer for this observation.

to the nature of its tense, but some of these restrictions certainly require further research. But, as noted above, this is not the only instance cross-linguistically of “say” predicates being defective in some way.

3.6 Intermediate summary

We’ve seen that there is an apparent near-synonymity between clauses that solely use *AGR-li* to express a communicative event and those that use a predicate communicating the manner of the communication, like *-loma* ‘speak’ together with *AGR-li*.

- (49) a. Nafula a-li eny-a ka-ma-beele.
 1Nafula 1SM-SAY 1SM.want-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘Nafula says that she wants milk.’
 b. Nafula a-lom-a a-li eny-a ka-ma-bele.
 1Nafula 1SM.PST-speak-FV 1SM-SAY 1SM.PST.want-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘Nafula said that she wants milk.’

As the evidence noted above made clear, however, there are stark differences in the properties of (matrix) *AGR-li* and other predicates like *-loma*, as summarized in (50).

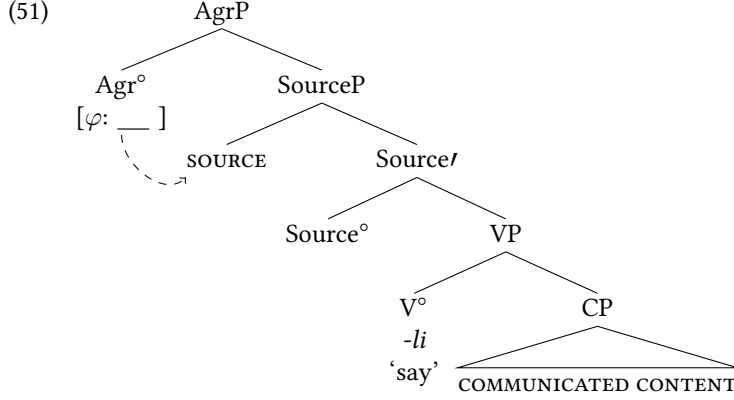
- (50) *AGR-li* vs *-loma* “speak” (and others)

	<i>AGR-li</i>	<i>-loma</i> ‘speak’
Subject agreement	✓	✓
Matrix use	✓	✓
Introduces COMMUNICATED CONTENT	✓	✗
Takes a GOAL argument	✗	✓
Manner modification	✗	✓
Temporal modification	✓	✓
Negation	✗	✓
Inflection for Tense/Aspect	✗	✓
Selects for a complement clause	✓	✗
Selects for a complement DP	✗	✓

Our claim is that *-loma* ‘speak’ is an eventive predicate taking an agent and describing the manner of communication and it thus behaves like canonical communicative events (allows GOALS, manner modification, negation, etc.). *AGR-li*, in contrast, is far more restricted. We suggest this is because it only lexicalizes the abstract verbal predicate “say,” and the lowest, stative *vP* shell.

Crucially, the particular semantic properties of *AGR-li* co-vary with the precise context in which it is embedded. If *AGR-li* combines with a predicate like ‘tell’ or ‘scream,’ there is a high likelihood that the COMMUNICATED CONTENT will be interpreted as what was literally said/articulated. When *AGR-li* combines with a predicate like ‘believe’ it will be less likely to encode a literal vocal utterance (more on this in the sections that follow).

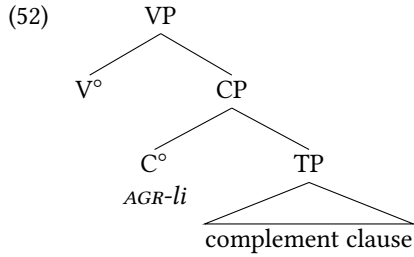
This section has argued that *AGR-li* should be treated as a verb that introduces COMMUNICATED CONTENT as its complement and a SOURCE as its subject. *AGR-li* lacks agentive and eventive syntax/semantics, corresponding roughly to the stative uses of “say” in English. We propose the analysis in (51) for *AGR-li*.



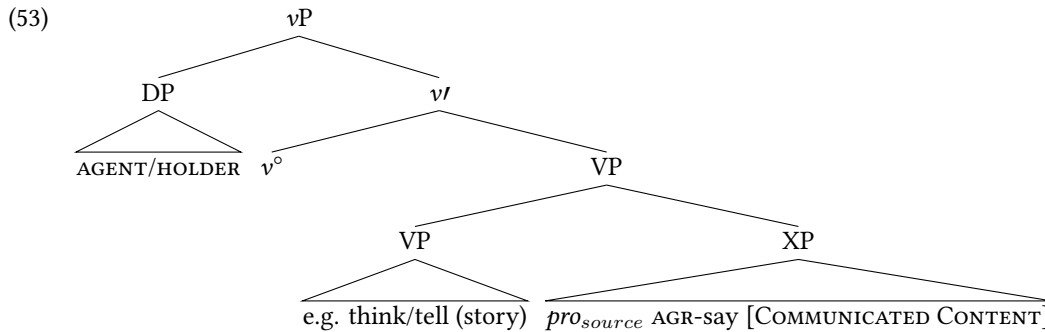
The subject of *AGR-li* (i.e. the SOURCE argument) is most often realized as an empty category (for the typical non-matrix uses of *AGR-li*). This empty category bears the hallmarks of *pro* when *AGR-li* is not the matrix predicate. By far the majority of constructions that use *AGR-li* (and pragmatic contexts where it is felicitous), the subject of *AGR-li* is coreferent with the matrix subject (hence, the long-standing conclusion that Lubukusu *AGR-li* necessarily agrees with matrix subjects). The analysis of a SOURCE subject of *AGR-li* predicts that there can be mismatches, however: §5 makes clear that this prediction is robustly upheld.

4 The external syntax of *AGR-li* clauses

We now turn to how the *AGR-li* clause combines with the matrix clause. Traditionally, *AGR-li* has been treated as a typical complementizer (Diercks, 2010, 2013). Carstens (2016) and Diercks et al. (2020) argue for some crucial tweaks to account for the agreement facts, but no previous account has diverged from the assumption that *AGR-li* heads a CP complement of the matrix predicate, presented in its simplest form here for expository purposes.

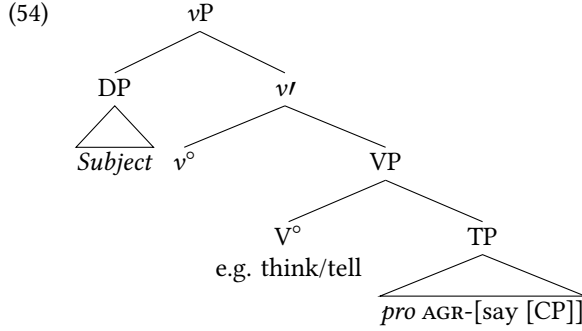


There are several reasons that (52) is problematic, especially if we take matrix *AGR-li* to be identical to the *AGR-li* that occurs in clausal complementation environments. As mentioned in the introduction, we argue for the analysis in (53) where the *AGR-li* clause is an adjunct to the main clause.



We also entertain a recent third possibility that has been proposed for Kipsigis (Driemel and Kouneli, 2025), which is a hybrid account that treats the complementizer-like element as a verbal “say” element, but differs in that

this element is embedded inside a TP that is selected by the matrix verb, illustrated in (54).²⁵



Traditional analyses like (52) do not predict that the C-like element should exhibit the syntactic properties of a clause-selecting verb, while the present analysis in (53) and its cousin in (54) predict that the verbal “say” has its own argument structure. The reason we do not adopt the analysis in (54) is because *AGR-li* clauses exhibit several properties that suggest that they are not arguments of the matrix predicate. Perhaps the clearest is that they occur in unselected environments where there is no clause-selecting matrix predicate (§4.2.1). One additional argument in favor of the modification analysis comes from the anti-factive behavior of *-li* clauses when they combine with factive predicates. It has been shown for several languages that complement clauses do not trigger the factive inference if they modify the matrix V(P) (Ozyildiz, 2017; Bondarenko, 2020; Bochnak and Matthewson, 2020; Major, 2024), which we show to be the case in Lubukusu (§4.3).

4.1 *AGR-li* selects for a CP; it does not head a CP

On traditional analyses of apparent complement clauses, complementizers head phrases that are selected by (for example) V or N. The verbal analysis put forth here suggests that *AGR-li* is a verb that introduces a clausal complement. As a result, if we can demonstrate that *AGR-li* takes a CP complement, it follows more naturally from the verbal analysis than a more traditional complementizer analysis like (52).

Wh-substitution is perhaps the clearest test in favor of a non-complementizer analysis of *AGR-li*. More specifically, if we take wh-pronouns to substitute in for particular constituents, we conclude that in English, “what” can stand in for the complement to “say” (obligatorily including ‘that’) (55a), but not the TP complement of ‘that,’ shown in (55b).²⁶

- (55) a. What_i did Nafula say t_i?
b. *What_i did Nafula say that t_i.

If we were to take *AGR-li* in Lubukusu to be a C°, which heads the complement of the matrix verb, we should expect *siina* ‘what’ to substitute in for the complement of the matrix verb (i.e. the constituent containing *AGR-li*), and not substitute for not the complement of *AGR-li* itself. Contrary to this expectation, it is possible for *siina* ‘what’ to be either the complement of the matrix verb or of *AGR-li*, giving rise to distinct interpretations. This is most clearly reflected by the answers to *siina* questions. Based on our proposal, this result is unsurprising because the *AGR-li*-phrase is not a CP, but the complement of *AGR-li* is a CP. The expected answer for a ‘what’ question targeting the complement of ‘scream’ is nominal, while a COMMUNICATED CONTENT answer is expected when ‘what’ targets the complement to *AGR-li*.

²⁵There is nothing ruling out the possibility that both of these analyses co-occur in Lubukusu, while only the complementation analysis is available in Kipsigis. We do not pursue this option for the purpose of putting forth a unified analysis of all *-li* contexts, and also because we have yet to encounter strong evidence for an instance of an *AGR-li* clause being a selected complement clause.

²⁶A reviewer makes an interesting observation that it seems that ‘what’ cannot stand in for a CP in English based on the ungrammaticality of e.g. *What does it seem. The point still holds that in English, *what* cannot target a constituent embedded under ‘that’, and must target a constituent that contains ‘that’ or is somehow incompatible with it.

- (56) a. Wekesa a-kanakan-a / a-kukuul-a / a-many-a siina?
 Wekesa 1SM.PST-think-FV / 1SM.PST-scream-FV / 1SM.PST-know-FV 7what
 ‘What did Wekesa think/scream/know about?’
asks something like “which issue:” an answer is a DP, e.g. “his many problems”
- b. Wekesa a-kanakan-a / a-kukuul-a / a-many-a a-li siina?
 Wekesa 1SM.PST-think-FV / 1SM.PST-scream-FV / 1SM.PST-know-FV 1SM-SAY what
 ‘What did Wekesa think/scream/know?’
asks something like “what content:” an answer is a CP, e.g. “that the children left”

The fact that the complement of *AGR-li* is a maximal CP is even more clear in (57), where natural answers to a similar question are themselves interrogative; we include an *in situ wh*-question and a *wh*-cleft, both answering a question where *siina* is the complement to *AGR-li*.

- (57) Q: Wafula a-a-reeb-a a-li siina?
 1Wafula 1SM-PST-ask-FV 1SM-SAY 7what
 ‘What did Wafula ask?’ (lit: ‘What did Wafula ask, saying?’)
- A1: Ba-ba-ana ba-a-kes-a ka-ma-indi liina?
 2-2-children 2SM-PST-harvest-FV 6-6-maize when
 ‘When did the children harvest the maize?’
- A2: Liina ni-lwo ba-ba-ana ba-a-kes-a ka-ma-indi ?
 when COMP-11 2-2-children 2SM-PST-harvest-FV 6-6-maize
 ‘When did the children harvest the maize?’

Examples like this are unexpected if *siina* in the questions in (56)-(57) is substituting for a TP. Instead, this clearly suggests that *siina* (when the complement of *AGR-li*) is substituting for a maximal CP, as even interrogative clauses are natural responses to those questions. The distinctions in what the *wh*-phrases stand in for in these instances confirms the pattern that we have been arguing for. *AGR-li* introduces COMMUNICATED CONTENT, but lexical matrix predicates on their own do not.²⁷

4.2 *AGR-li* clauses are not arguments

The basic selectional properties are the same for *AGR-li* when it is the sole matrix predicate as when it combines with another predicate, which follows naturally from an analysis that treats *AGR-li* as a “say” predicate in all contexts. The next question is whether we can provide evidence that *AGR-li* clauses are adjuncts/modifiers or arguments. In many languages, both true complementation and adjunct/modifier analyses have been proposed to exist. In Washo, Bochnak and Hanink (2021) argue that clauses bearing nominal morphology in Washo are arguments, while those with clause-linking morphology are modifiers (Washo does not exhibit “say” complementation). A similar split has been argued in “say” complementation languages as well (e.g. Buryat (Bondarenko, 2020, 2022), Japanese (Shimamura, 2018; Özyıldız and Uegaki, 2023), Turkish (Özyıldız, 2017; Özyıldız et al., 2018; Özyıldız and Uegaki, 2023), and Uyghur (Major, 2021, 2024), although analyses differ with respect to the precise lexical status of “say.” In each of the languages above, the clauses which have more nominal tendencies can be promoted under passivization, can be sentential subjects, and can occur with factive predicates. On the other hand, the finite clauses (generally introduced by “say”) eliminate the factive presupposition, cannot occur in subject position, occur in unselected environments, and do not bear case-marking. *AGR-li* clauses correspond to the latter cluster of properties, to the extent that they can be diagnosed in Lubukusu.

We begin by showing that *AGR-li* is able to occur in unselected clauses (§4.2.1), which is our first reason for suggesting that it is not an argument. After a brief discussion of expletive objects, we then demonstrate that like Washo, Turkic, and Mongolic, that *AGR-li* clauses are interpreted as non-factive when they occur with factive predicates, which is suggestive that *AGR-li* clauses are modifiers (not taken as complements to factive verbs).

²⁷Even if one wishes to maintain a non-verbal analysis of *AGR-li*, any successful analysis of these constructions needs to explain both how the complement to *AGR-li* can be targeted by a *wh*-question to the exclusion of *AGR-li*, which does not follow straightforwardly from any pre-existing analysis.

4.2.1 Unselected *AGR-li*

The fact that there are instances of *AGR-li* that occur in entirely unselected environments serves as immediate evidence that at least some instances of *AGR-li* are not arguments. One such example involves an *AGR-li* clause functioning similar to a purpose clause (58), where it introduces the reason provided by the subject for ‘going outside.’

- (58) Wafula a-kha-ch-a a-nje a-li a-nyol-e e-m-beo.
 1Wafula 1SM-PFV-go-FV 16-outside 1SM-SAY 1SM-get-SUBJ 9-9-air
 ‘Wafula went outside saying he would get fresh air.’

A sentence like (58) is difficult to explain on an analysis that *AGR-li* is a declarative-embedding complementizer akin to English *that*. However, this is almost identical to the English equivalent that literally contains the verb ‘saying’ (i.e. “Wafula went outside saying he would get fresh air”).²⁸

One might suggest that this configuration is roughly equivalent to a ‘because’ clause in English, but it should be noted that there is no presupposition associated with the COMMUNICATED CONTENT introduced by *AGR-li*, as it can be cancelled without leading to a contradiction (59).

- (59) Wekesa a-ch-a mu-n-ju mw-ewe a-li a-lw-iile, nekakhali eny-a
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-go-FV 18-9-house 18-his 1SM-SAY 1SM-be.sick-PFV but 1SM.want-FV
 a-lol-e e-TV.
 1SM-watch-SUBJ 9-TV
 ‘Wekesa went to his house saying he was sick/tired, but (I know that) he wanted to watch TV.’

Again, this suggests that the unselected *AGR-li* is simply describing the stated rationale for the main-clause action, not a presuppositional reason adjunct clause.

There are also instances where an unselected *AGR-li* clause is interpreted as communication rather than a rationale. The examples below illustrate this with a full transitive main clause predicate paired with an *AGR-li* adjunct clause.²⁹

- (60) a. O-mu-keni a-ly-a bu-suma bwaangu lukali a-li a-bu-siim-a.
 1-1-guest 1SM.PST-eat-FV 14-ugali quickly very 1SM-SAY 1SM.PST-14OM-like-FV
 ‘The guest ate the ugali very quickly, saying that they(sg) liked it.’
 b. O-mw-aana a-a-som-a sii-tabu a-li si-layi.
 1-1-child 1SM-PST-read-FV 7-book 1SM-SAY 7-good
 ‘The child read the book saying it’s good.’
 c. O-mu-khasi a-a-nyw-a bu-yu a-li bu-layi khu-b-eebo
 1-1-woman 1SM-PST-drink-FV 14-porridge 1SM-SAY 14-good 17-2-new.mother
 ‘The woman drank the porridge saying it’s good for new mothers.’

These examples minimally illustrate that there exist instances of *AGR-li* clauses merging as adjuncts, i.e. which is not selected by the matrix predicate. So clearly *AGR-li* clauses *can* be adjunct clauses; we pursue the stronger claim that *AGR-li* subordinate clauses are all adjunct clauses, even in instances that have typically been analyzed as complement clauses.

²⁸These types of unselected clauses are cross-linguistically common in languages with *say*-complementation. We take the structures in Lubukusu to be akin to unselected questions in Korean (Kim, 2018) and Japanese (Kim, 2018; Shimamura, 2018). A reviewer invites us to connect our work with this literature. Since the initial submission of this paper, Özyıldız and Uegaki (2024) was written, which provides a *say*-complementation-based analysis on precisely these types of utterances, which we take to be (at least roughly) equivalent to unselected clauses in Lubukusu.

²⁹Our thanks to a reviewer for suggesting these particular sorts of examples.

4.2.2 Quasi-expletives in object position

This section offers another argument for *AGR-li* clauses being unselected by matrix predicates and likely in an adjunct relationship within the matrix clause. The predicate *-yokel-* “scream” is not inherently a communicative predicate; it is an unergative activity predicate. Without an applicative, as in (61a), it is intransitive. With an applicative, a recipient/addressee object can be included.

- (61) a. Nafula a-yokel-a.
1Nafula 1SM.PST-1SG.OM-scream-FV
‘Nafula screamed.’
b. Nafula a-n-jokel-el-a.
1Nafula 1SM.PST-1SG.OM-scream-APPL-FV
‘Nafula screamed at me.’

We see the communicated content nominal *kamakuwa* ‘words’ serving a similar kind of expletive function as a phatic nominal in object position (an object quasi-expletive). Generally, *-yokela* ‘scream, make loud noises’ is intransitive (unergative) but as is common it can occur with a cognate object (as [Opdycke 1941](#) discusses for English).

- (62) Wekesa a-yokel-a lu-yoka.
1Wekesa 1SM.PST-scream-FV 1I-scream
‘Wekesa screamed a scream.’
(63) Wekesa a-yokel-a ka-ma-khuwa.
1Wekesa 1SM.PST-scream-FV 6-6-words
‘Wekesa screamed something/words.’

Notably, this predicate can readily occur with an *AGR-li* phrase as well, containing content communicated in the exchange.

- (64) Wekesa a-yokel-a ka-ma-khuwa a-li Wafula a-ch-a.
1Wekesa 1SM.PST-scream-FV 6-6-words 1SM-SAY 1Wafula 1SM.PST-go-FV
‘Wekesa screamed something/words, saying that Wafula left.’

We are left with little (or perhaps no) reason in examples like this to suppose that the *AGR-li* phrase is selected by the matrix predicate.

This stands out somewhat clearly when a standard objecthood diagnostic is used: object markers on verbs agree in noun class features with structural objects. The pragmatics of object-marking are complex (see [Sikuku and Diercks to appear](#)), but a relatively straightforward discourse context that consistently licenses co-occurrence of an object marker with an object is a verum focus context (somewhat similar to English emphatic *do*).

- (65) a. Wekesa a-ka-yokel-a ka-ma-khuwa a-li Wafula a-cha.
1Wekesa 1SM.PST-6OM-scream-FV 6-6-words 1SM-SAY 1Wafula 1SM.PST-go-FV
‘Wekesa DID scream something/the words saying Wafula left!’
b. Wekesa a-li-yokel-a lii-khuwa a-li Wafula a-cha.
1Wekesa 1SM.PST-5OM-scream-FV 5-word 1SM-SAY 1Wafula 1SM.PST-go-FV
‘Wekesa DID scream something/the word saying Wafula left!’

In these instances, there is a structural object (the phatic object *likhuwa/kamakuwa*) that occurs in positions where objects occur, and marked by object markers how objects are, agreeing in noun classes 5/6 as expected. *AGR-li*, in contrast, isn’t marked for class 5/6, and is instead sharing noun class features with the communicator (class 1 Wekesa) here. We are left with little reason to assume that the *AGR-li* phrase is selected by the matrix predicate in

this instance, or is grammatically functioning as an object of the matrix predicate. This all follows straightforwardly, however, if *AGR-li* phrases are in fact verbal phrases that are incorporated via adjunction to the matrix clause rather than being selected by the matrix communication predicate.³⁰

4.2.3 On argumenthood

One issue raised by a reviewer is that there is a sense in which the complement to *AGR-li* is interpreted like an argument of the matrix predicate. If we take the *AGR-li* clause to be an argument of the matrix clause, this comes for free, but we lose the ability to explain many of the novel data introduced in this paper. It is still important to consider the relationship between the *AGR-li* clause and the matrix VP that leads to it being interpreted like its an argument. One could, in principle, map the content of the complement to *AGR-li* to a nominal or the matrix eventuality using e.g. a content function (Kratzer, 2006; Moulton, 2009) or some other thematic linking mechanism, but we avoid making such a claim here. Consider the English cases in (66), where an *-ing* clause modifies the matrix VP, which lacks an overt internal argument:

- (66) a. Justine drank, consuming every last Guinness.
- b. Justine found a solution to his boredom, consuming every last Guinness.
- c. Justine drank beer, consuming every last Guinness.

We interpret cases like (66a) as instances where *drink* is functioning as an (intransitive) activity predicate that is modified by an adjunct *-ing* clause that is headed by *consume* that happens to introduce a complement that is interpreted as the object of *drink*. This relationship is one of interpretive possibility and not a requirement, as (66b-66c) do not have such an interpretation. One could in principle argue for a hard-coded formal relationship between what is interpreted as the implicit object of *drink* and the contents of the clausal adjunct, but we suggest that this is strictly about pragmatics and discourse coherence.

- (67) a. Justine told me (something silly), saying that Manchester United would win the EPL.
- b. Justine spoke, saying that Manchester United would win the EPL this year.
- c. Justine organized a party, saying he expected Manchester United to win the EPL.

In (67), the same dynamic arises for *saying* clauses. In the first two cases, the *saying* clause is interpreted as the content of what is said. In the case of (67a), there is an overt object, *something silly* which one could suggest gets its content from the *say* clause. With *spoke* (67b), an intransitive predicate, the modifier is interpreted the same way, but lacks the ability to introduce an internal argument that the contents of the *saying* clause could map on to. In the case of (67c), the contents of the *saying* clause can either be Justine’s stated rationale or can describe an inference made by the speaker that is construed as the reason that a party was organized. We suggest that these modifiers do not have a selectional relationship with the main verb, but often give rise to interpretations that are roughly equivalent to typical [V CP] structures. We suggest this is equivalent to what happens in Lubukusu. A careful investigation of the distribution of null and implicit arguments in Lubukusu is in order, which we set aside for future research.^{31,32} We discuss selection in more detail in §7.

4.3 Factivity

As mentioned above, it has been argued for many languages that factivity is determined by properties of both the matrix predicate and the complement clause. In Washo, Bochnak and Hanink (2021) demonstrate that factive predicates only combine with nominalized clauses, while non-factive predicates combine with modificational VP adjuncts. In Azeri (Bondarenko, 2023), Buryat (Bondarenko, 2020), Turkish Ozyıldız (2017), and Uyghur (Major, 2024), factive

³⁰Mittwoch (2005) demonstrates that almost all transitive verbs can occur with null objects under the right discourse conditions in English. Other usually transitive predicates can function as intransitive activity predicates. We suggest that VPs modified by *AGR-li* consist of both VPs involving intransitive uses of transitive predicates and VPs containing null objects.

³¹Goodhue and Shimoyama (2022) argue that (at least) a subset of Japanese *to* clauses co-occur with a silent pronominal with properties that align fairly well with our claims in this section. We do not have the same kinds of morpho-syntactic evidence from Japanese as motivation.

³²Mittwoch (2005) demonstrates that almost all transitive verbs can occur with null objects under the right discourse conditions in English. Other usually transitive predicates can function as intransitive activity predicates. We suggest that VPs modified by *AGR-li* consist of both VPs involving intransitive uses of transitive predicates and VPs containing null objects.

predicates are only factive when they combine with nominalized clauses and are non-factive when they combine with finite clauses, which are taken to be modifiers. If we take *AGR-li* clauses to be “say” clauses that introduce finite CPs, “say” introduces the propositional CP as its complement and modifies the matrix VP. In this configuration we should not expect the CP to be presupposed, both because “say” is not factive and because it is a modifier. Lubukusu has three distinct strategies for combining a factive verb with a CP: *bali*, *AGR-li*, or the complementizer *nge*. Each has a distinct interpretation (*AGR-li* is marginal), but the factive presupposition is only triggered by *nge*. This is true in the affirmative and the negative, which we provide in (68-69) below:

- (68) a. Travis a-sangal-a ba-li Arsenal y-a-tibi-a ku-mw-inyao.
 1Travis 1SM.PST-be.happy-FV 2SM-say 9Arsenal 9SM-PST-lost-FV 3-3-game
 ‘Travis was happy that Arsenal lost the game.’
 b. ?Travis a-sangal-a a-li Arsenal y-a-tibi-a ku-mw-inyao.
 1Travis 1SM.PST-be.happy-FV 1SM-say 9Arsenal 9SM-PST-lost-FV 3-3-game
 ‘Travis was happy that Arsenal lost the game.’
 c. Travis a-sangal-a nge Arsenal y-a-tibi-a ku-mw-inyao.
 1Travis 1SM.PST-be.happy-FV COMP 9Arsenal 9SM-PST-lost-FV 3-3-game
 ‘Travis was happy that Arsenal lost the game.’
- (69) a. Travis se-a-sangal-a ba-li Arsenal y-a-tibi-a ku-mw-inyao ta.
 1Travis NEG-1SM.PST-be.happy-FV 2SM-say 9Arsenal 9SM-PST-lost-FV 3-3-game NEG
 ‘Travis was not happy that Arsenal lost the game.’
 • *It is not necessarily true that Arsenal lost the game. It may be a rumor.*
 b. ?Travis se-a-sangal-a a-li Arsenal y-a-tibi-a ku-mw-inyao ta.
 1Travis NEG-1SM.PST-be.happy-FV 1SM-say 9Arsenal 9SM-PST-lost-FV 3-3-game NEG
 ‘Travis was not happy that Arsenal lost the game.’
 • *Using ‘ali’ downgrades the grammaticality but the truth of Arsenal losing is not guaranteed...it may just be an excuse for his lack of happiness.*
 c. Travis se-a-sangal-a nge Arsenal y-a-tibi-a kumwinyao ta.
 1Travis NEG-1SM.PST-be.happy-FV COMP 9Arsenal 9SM-PST-lost-FV 3-3-game NEG
 ‘Travis was not happy that Arsenal lost the game.’
 • *Arsenal actually lost the game.*

If we take the absence of factivity to demonstrate modification and the presence of a factive presupposition to correlate with complement-hood, we would conclude that only *nge* is selected as a complement to the matrix predicate. We further expect the absence of factivity because “say” is non-factive and selects the CP as its complement. This is of course not definitive evidence of a “say” adjunction analysis of *AGR-li*, but our analysis does offer an explanation for these facts. There is little research on *nge* and there are many open questions that we set aside for future research.

For the present, it is worth highlighting the fact that while there is no factive presupposition for clauses introduced by both *AGR-li* and *bali*, there is nonetheless an interpretive difference between them (indicated in the comments beneath the examples above). This difference is linked to SOURCE-identification, which we return to at greater length in Section 5. The present proposal offers a way of thinking about the agreement on *-li* and what determines which form will be preferred in a given environment. We will demonstrate that the preference with non-factive predicates is based on discourse context and whether the matrix subject is also the SOURCE. *ba-li* bears 3rd person, plural marking which often carries an impersonal function in the language.

The initial description of (non)factivity interactions with *AGR-li* was established in Diercks (2010, 2013), which noted (as we replicate above) that emotive factive matrix predicates were degraded with an agreeing *AGR-li* form, instead preferring *ba-li* (analyzed there to be a nonagreeing complementizer).³³ If we re-analyze *ba-li* in these instances as an impersonal agreeing form agreeing with a covert third plural (class 2) subject of “say,” a new line of

³³They were often marked with a “*” in that work, though sometimes as “?” or “??”

analysis emerges. The competition between *AGR-li* and *ba-li* indicates different subjects of “say:” that is, whether the proposition is generally “said” to be true (= *bali*) or only “said” to be true by the matrix subject (= *AGR-li*). It makes intuitive sense that *ba-li* would be preferred in the case of emotive factives: *AGR-li* in cases like (69b) implies that only *Travis* is the *SOURCE* of the content that made him unhappy. With *bali*, as in (69a), the impersonal component gives rise to an interpretation where the *SOURCE* is construed as people in general (likely including the speaker), which roughly approximates the interpretation of factives in English, where the speaker presupposes the content to be true. For *AGR-li*, the choice to indicate that the *SOURCE* of the content is only the matrix subject (and to assert that that individual says something) implies that the content is not generally said to be true, which gives rise to a radically different meaning from English factives.³⁴

4.4 Assumptions regarding clausal adjunction

In this section we give an all-too-brief introduction to multi-verb constructions in Lubukusu, with the goal of showing that *AGR-li* adjunction constructions are not atypical for the language more generally.

4.4.1 A brief primer on Lubukusu multi-verb constructions

Here we overview different strategies within Lubukusu for complex sentences containing multiple verbal elements. Some of these are fairly standard crosslinguistically (conjunction/coordination) and are included here as points of contrast with the others.

(70) Strategies for multi-verb constructions in Lubukusu

Strategy	Form	Interpretation	Internal structure
Standard conjunction	<i>mala, lundi</i>	standard conjunction	CPs
Ne-adjunction	<i>n(e)-</i> verbal prefix	simultaneous events	finite TPs
Narrative clause chains	adjunct clauses with actual, subjunctive	subsequent events	MoodP
vP-modifying truncated adjunct clause	[_{XP} <i>AGR-verb-a</i>]	manner modification of matrix predicate	[_{vP} [_{vP}] XP]

We won’t be able to offer a full investigation of each of these strategies; what we do show is that VP-modifying truncated adjunct clauses show a range of similar properties to *AGR-li* clauses, and these are clearly differentiated from other kinds of strategies for forming multi-verb sentences. The goal is to demonstrate that the analysis of *AGR-li* as verbal, frequently occurring in a multi-verb construction (when it appears in any non-matrix usages), is in fact typical and unsurprising for Lubukusu more generally. These strategies for forming multi-verb serialization-type constructions are clearly in need of further investigation in their own right, but for now we content ourselves with these initial descriptions of the facts.

Lubukusu uses different kinds of the coordination for different categories of conjuncts; *mala* and *lundi* allow any two clauses to be conjoined regardless of their relationship or event structure (71).

- (71) Wafula ech-a likolooba mala / lundi ba-ba-ana ba-kh-ach-e muchuli.
1Wafula 1SM.PST.come-FV yesterday CONJ / CONJ 2-2-children 1SM-FUT-go-FUT tomorrow
‘Wafula came yesterday and the children will leave.’

Next are adjunct clauses introduced by the particle *NE*; we will describe the properties of *NE* here, but won’t attempt a complete analysis. The morphologically defining feature of *NE*-adjunction is that the the verb of the modifying clause displays *n-/ne-/na-* subordinating morphology as a prefix to the verbal form. Whereas truncated adjunct clauses are highly restricted, *NE*-adjunction can link any two clauses that can occur simultaneously (essentially equivalent to English *while*-constructions).

³⁴This option is likely marginal because there are many other constructions that more accurately represent all of the relevant information (e.g. *Travis is unhappy because he thinks that...*).

- (72) Wekesa osy-a e-nyama [n-a-nyw-a ka-ma-lwa.]
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST.roast-FV 9-meat NE-1SM-drink-FV 6-6-beer
 ‘Wekesa roasted meat while drinking beer.’

Notice here that ‘drinking beer’ is not a conceivable manner in which ‘roasting meat’ is done: NE-adjuncts can be unrelated activities to the matrix predicate, as long as they are simultaneous activities. In general, the internal syntax of NE-adjuncts is the full syntax of finite clauses. (73) shows that NE-adjuncts can contain independent subjects, can be negated, and can occur with an applicative.

- (73) Wekesa osy-a e-nyama [Nafula n-a-kha-nyw-el-a o-mu-khulundu ka-ma-lwa
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST.roast-FV 9-meat 1Nafula NE-1SM.PST-NEG-drink-APPL-FV 1-1-pastor 6-6-beer
 ta.]
 NEG
 ‘Wekesa roasted meat while Nafula was not drinking beer on behalf of the pastor.’

We assume these adjuncts are full CPs and NE is a C° that lowers onto the verbal form.

NE-adjuncts can also receive independent modification as in (74a): in this example, the partitive class 17 *-kho* enclitic is used to modify the matrix predicate, and the NE-adjunct includes an adverbial. The meanings of these are at odds (*a little bit* vs. *intensely/a lot*), so it is clear that the modifiers are modifying the main predicate and the adjunct predicate separately. (74a) shows that NE-adjuncts can be overtly tense-marked with various tenses. The tense must match the main clause predicate because of the simultaneity requirement of NE-adjuncts, but there is no restriction on tense-marking (similar to standard conjunction, but a distinction from the the VP-modifying truncated adjuncts we will look at below).

- (74) a. Wekesa osy-a(-kho) e-nyama Nafula n-a-nyw-a ka-ma-lwa (lukali).
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST.roast-FV-17 9-meat 1Nafula NE-1SM.PST-drink-FV 6-6-beer intensely
 ‘Wekesa roasted meat a little bit while Nafula was drinking a lot of beer.’
 b. Wekesa a(-kh-) osy(-e) e-nyama Nafula n-a(-kha-) nyw(-e) ka-ma-lwa.
 1Wekesa 1SM-FUT.roast-FUT 9-meat 1Nafula NE-1SM-FUT-drink-FUT 6-6-beer
 ‘Wekesa will roast meat while Nafula will drink beer.’

As in many other languages, particularly languages with serial verb constructions (e.g. Baker, 1989; Collins, 1997), there is a multi-verb construction in Lubukusu equivalent to (71) in many senses but which lacks an overt conjunction. In these structures, it is possible for the clause-linking to occur below T (at roughly Asp), but there is remains no requirement that the clauses describe a singular event, able to link ‘coming’ and ‘leaving,’ for example. We refer to these as narrative clause chains. The narrative tense prefix *a-* is used for non-future tenses, and future tense uses the subjunctive for the same interpretive effect of the narrative clause chain.³⁵

- (75) a. Wafula ech-a a-a-ch-a.
 1Wafula 1SM.PST.come-FV 1SM-NAR-go-FV
 ‘Wafula came and (then) went.’
 b. Wafula a-kh-ech-e a-ch-e.
 1Wafula 1SM-FUT-come-FUT 1SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Wafula will come and (then) leave.’

- (76) a. SM-(a-) verb.root-a:
 Narrative tense (the ‘actual’) is used for past tense events that have actually occurred at the narrative time (77a).
 b. SM-verb.root(-e):
 Subjunctive is used for sequences of future (irrealis) events unrealized at the narrative time (77b).

³⁵The narrative tense here is the same form that Safir et al. (2020) previously analyzed as an ‘actual’ clause.

This is illustrated in (77), where (77a) is past tense (and the chained clause uses the narrative *-a-*) and (77b) is a future tense construction where the chained clause uses the subjunctive.

- (77) a. Wekesa osy-a e-nyam-a a-a-(ki-)ly-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST.roast-FV 9-meat 1SM-NAR-9OM-eat-FV
 ‘Wekesa roasted meat and (then) ate it.’
 b. Wekesa a-kh-osy-e e-nyama a-(ki-)ly-e.
 1Wekesa 1SM-FUT-roast-FUT 9-meat 1SM-9OM-eat-SUBJ
 ‘Wekesa will roast meat and eat (it).’

There is no overt conjunction in these examples, but there is also no tense specified after the first verb. The interpretation of non-initial, mood-marked predicates is dependent on the tense established by the first predicate (or the discourse in some cases). This is not unlike the narrative function of present tense in English, where the chain of events is obligatorily interpreted as a progression (for overview and discussion, see Anand and Tooservandani, 2020; Anand and Toosarvandani, to appear; Pancheva and Zubizarreta, 2020).

These cases differ from NE-adjunction: with NE-adjunction, simultaneity is required. The examples in (77) can be compared with the NE-form in (78), wherein the roasting and the eating have to be simultaneous:

- (78) Wekesa osy-a e-nyama n-a-ki-ly-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST.roast-FV 9-meat NE-1SM-9OM-eat-FV
 ‘Wekesa roasted meat while eating it.’
 (i.e. *roasting it and eating bits as he went*)

4.4.2 Truncated verbal adjunction

In West African languages such as Avatime (Major and Torrence, 2020), “say” complementation closely resembles serial verb constructions in the language. In Turkic and Mongolic, “say” complementation is accomplished with *converbs*. This section is intended to briefly demonstrate that there exist agreeing modifier clauses in Lubukusu that are previously undescribed in the literature on Lubukusu and which are different from the multiple-verb constructions described above; we take to be (at least roughly) structurally equivalent to *AGR-li* clauses. An example is provided in (79):

- (79) a. Wekesa a-kha-engil-e mu-nju (a-) tim-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-FUT-enter-FUT 18-house 1SM-run-FV
 ‘Wekesa will enter the house running.’
 Nafula { a-a-nyw-a / a-kha-nyw-e } ka-ma-beele (a-) kesemulil-a.
 1Nafula 1SM-PST-drink-FV 1SM-FUT-drink-FV 6-6-milk 1SM-sweat-FV
 ‘Nafula drank/will drink milk sweating’
 b. Wekesa { a-a-som-a / a-kha-som-a sii-tabu } (a-) keend-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-read-FV 1SM-FUT-read-FV 7-book 1SM-walk-FV
 ‘He read/will read a book walking.’

This strategy is highly restricted with respect to whether the modifier is felicitous. The contrast seems to hinge on whether the modifying clause sufficiently qualifies as a modifier of the matrix VP. For instance, in (80) only *dancing* (80a) can be considered an actual way of entering the house. A similarly simultaneous activity of greeting people in (80b) is nonetheless not itself the manner of entering, and is less acceptable using the truncated adjunct clause, instead requiring the NE subordinator.

- (80) a. Wafula engil-a mu-nju (??n-)a-khin-a ka-ma-beka.
 1Wafula 1SM.enter-FV 18-house (??NE-)1SM-dance-FV 6-6-shoulders
 ‘Wafula entered the house dancing.’ (*dancing shoulders = a particular kind of dance*)

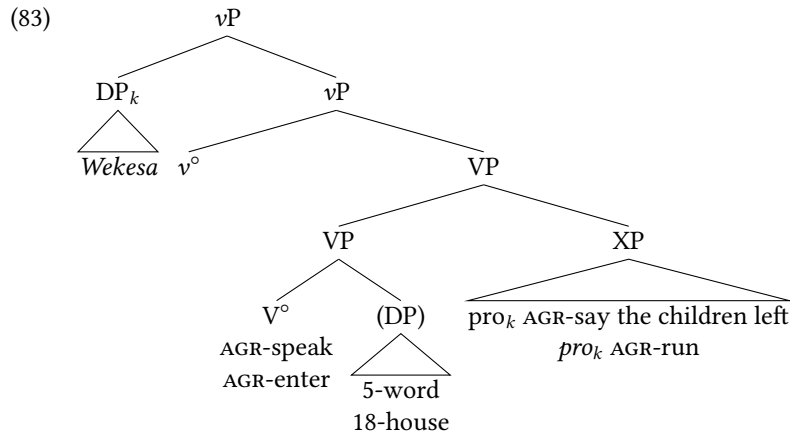
- b. Wafula engil-a mu-nju ??(n-)a-khesi-a buli mundu.
 1Wafula 1SM.enter-FV 18-house ??(NE-)1SM-greet-FV every 1person
 ‘Wafula entered the house (while) greeting everyone.’

The general pattern that we observe is that the resulting description needs to be interpretable as a single event, not as describing separate events.

We take these truncated verbal adjunctions to encompass the same general syntax as *AGR-li*, in line with the way that converbs, serial verb constructions, and *-ing* clauses are used to form “say” complementation in other languages.³⁶ More work is needed to fully understand the syntax and semantics of truncated verbal adjunction, but the fact that they exist and display agreement, like *AGR-li* clauses, at least suggests that we are not proposing a structure for *AGR-li* clauses that is not observed anywhere else in the grammar.

In summary, we assume the analysis of (81) and (82) is the same, as shown in (83).

- (81) Wekesa [a-kha-] engil-e mu-nju [a-] tim-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-FUT-enter-FUT 18-house 1SM-run-FV
 ‘Wekesa will enter the house running.’
- (82) Wekesa [a-a-] lom-a li-khuwa [a-] li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-say-FV 5-word 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa said that the children left.’



4.4.3 *AGR-li* in clause chains

The existence of narrative clause chains formed via adjunction, introduced above, suggests that we might expect *AGR-li* clauses to appear in these chains. We show here that this prediction is confirmed, though a full exploration must be left to future work. The verb *-lila* ‘cry’ in (84a) is not construed as a communicative predicate. But communication can be encoded with the presence of *AGR-li*, as in (84b).

- (84) a. Wekesa a-a-lil-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-cry-FV
 ‘Wekesa cried.’
- b. Wekesa a-a-lil-a *(a-li) maayi a-a-tib-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-cry-FV 1SM-SAY 1mother 1SM-PST-get.lost-FV
 ‘Wekesa cried, saying his mother passed away. (lit. got lost, fig. died)’

³⁶Privoznov (2022) and Major (2021), and Major (2024) argue that *-ing* and converbs are in the same class of elements. It should be noted that English *-ing* clauses are subject to restrictions with respect to whether they can function as VP modifiers without an accompanying preposition/conjunction.

In (85), the *AGR-li* clause specifies what was communicated (“said”) via a series of actions ‘say/speak,’ ‘cry,’ and ‘sing.’

- (85) Wekesa a-lom-ile a-a-lil-a e-emb-a a-li maawe a-a-tib-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM-speak-PFV 1SM-NAR-cry 1SM.NAR-sing-FV 1SM-SAY 1mother 1SM-PST-get.lost-FV
 ‘Wekesa spoke, cried, and sang saying that his mother passed away.’ (lit. got lost, fig. died)

In (85) the entire matrix clause has a single TAM marker (the *-ile* perfective), and the interpretation of the *AGR-li* clause is such that there are ‘saying/speaking,’ ‘crying,’ and ‘singing’ events and the result of all of these events is the communication of the message that Wekesa’s mother passed away. This arrangement would be quite surprising if the *AGR-li* clause were the complement of only “speak” or only “sing.” As is evident in (86), the verbs in the clause chaining construction may themselves take arguments, but this is not disruptive to the availability of the *AGR-li* verb in the chain:

- (86) Wekesa a-ulil-a li-khuwa a-a-lil-a eemb-a lu-lw-imbo a-li maawe
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-hear-FV 5-word/news 1SM-NAR-cry-FV 1SM.NAR.sing-FV 11-11-song 1SM-SAY 1mother
 a-a-tib-a.
 1SM-PST-get.lost-FV
 ‘Wekesa heard the news, cried, sang the song, saying that his mother passed away.’ (lit. got lost, fig. died)
 (all interpreted as part of a single grieving event)

As with many patterns mentioned in this paper, this is largely unexpected if *AGR-li* is analyzed as a complementizer heading a complement clause argument of the main verb communication predicate. It is much easier to understand as a modifier of the matrix VP.

4.5 Intermediate Summary

In this section we have further explored various implications of the analysis we advance in this paper. First, we argued that *AGR-li* is not itself a CP, but selects for a CP. We then presented a range of empirical arguments suggesting that *AGR-li* clauses are not themselves arguments of the matrix predicate, instead being incorporated into matrix clauses via adjunction. This is evident in instances of obviously-unselected *AGR-li*, and in instances of phatic objects present, quite distinct from the *AGR-li* clauses themselves.

- (87) Arguments for adjunct status of *AGR-li* clauses
- *AGR-li* appears in unselected contexts.
 - *AGR-li* appears with phatic objects.
 - *AGR-li* clauses lack a factive presupposition.
 - *AGR-li* occurs in narrative clause chains.
 - Matrix predicates select for DPs, *AGR-li* selects for CPs.

5 On Sources

The previous sections argued in favor of an analysis that treats *AGR-li* as a type of adjunct with the full internal syntax of matrix *AGR-li* clauses, including a *SOURCE* argument. Here we demonstrate the range of interpretive effects this has in subordination contexts. Diercks (2010, 2013) first reported that the choice of *AGR-li* element has interpretive effects. Notice in (88) that both the subject-agreeing form and the nonagreeing *bali* form are possible.

- (88) Wekesa a-subil-a a-li/ba-li ba-ba-ana ba-rekukh-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-believe-FV 1SM-SAY/2SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-leave-FV
 ‘Wekesa believes that the children left.’

The initial work on *AGR-li* noted that whereas *AGR-li* (*ali* here) seemed to have a neutral interpretation, *bali* had a flavor similar to a hearsay evidential, that is, that the reported information did not arise from the matrix subject (we

discuss the connection with reportative evidentials in §7.3).³⁷ On the analysis we adopt here, when using *ali* in (88) the speaker indicates that the matrix subject is both the holder of the belief and the SOURCE of the content, and with *bali*, the speaker indicates that the belief holder is not the SOURCE (more on this below). This section demonstrates that by manipulating the communicated content and the matrix predicate, we can predict which form of *-li* will arise, or at least which will be preferred. We will use the terms *impersonal* and *nonagreeing* to refer to these uses of *bali* when it is not sharing features (i.e. not coreferent) with the matrix subject. The form *ba-* is the class 2 (third person plural) subject marker, and we will attribute this hearsay-like reading to a generic, impersonal “they say” type reading.

This section diagnoses the presence of a SOURCE argument in *AGR-li* constructions in a variety of ways. §5.2 explores the interpretation of *AGR-li* and the impersonal *bali* with matrix attitude predicates, exploring the interpretive effects that occur between them and showing how they can be explained via a SOURCE argument of *AGR-li*. §5.3 discusses predicates like *hear*, where the subject is the one who has received (in some way) the communicated content. §5.4 discusses instances of *AGR-li* agreeing with inanimate sources; we construct a number of instances that make clear that the speaker’s source of the communicated content is what triggers agreement on *AGR-li*. In §5.4 we manipulate the matrix predicate, semantic content, and pragmatic context to create examples where it is dispreferred to interpret the matrix subject as the SOURCE of *AGR-li*: in these instances, as predicted, *AGR-li* is dispreferred to agree with the matrix subject.

In the end, we see that the analysis presented in this paper (that *AGR-li* is a verbal predicate asserted as a modifier of the matrix clause) can explain a wide variety of interpretive effects related to the SOURCE argument of *AGR-li*. A small subset of these interpretive effects were previously documented (but unexplained) by Diercks (2010, 2013), but most are novel evidence here. Altogether, they are completely unexplained on any existing analysis of *AGR-li* as an agreeing complementizer, but are readily explained by a verbal analysis with the argument structure that we propose.

5.1 Distinguishing SOURCES from subjects

Before moving to the complexity of the *AGR-li* data, we want to clarify how (in complementation contexts) the SOURCE of COMMUNICATED CONTENT can be distinct from matrix subjects. As noted by Sells (1987) and Clements (1975), the nature of the SOURCE of an information report at times plays a central syntactic roles (both for say-verbs, also for logophoric phenomena). With attitude verbs, speech verbs, and illocutionary predicates, it is typical for the speakers’s SOURCE to be identical to the matrix subject. In other words, Kayla is the SOURCE of the content and the AGENT/HOLDER (89). So, if a speaker utters one of the sentences in (89), they are typically indirectly reporting information in the embedded clause that they presumably find reportable based on some degree of evidence from the referent of the matrix subject (Kayla).

- (89) a. Kayla thinks/believes/knows that durian smells amazing.
 b. Kayla said/explained/screamed that durian smells amazing.
 c. Kayla wondered/asked/inquired about whether durian smells amazing.
 d. Kayla demanded/ordered that you smell the durian.

That is to say, presumably here the speaker observed Kayla in some interaction or behaving in some way that merits the speaker describing Kayla as having communicated something, or having the attitude being described.

Communicative reception verbs introduce a different pattern (90). With these predicates, context determines the likelihood that the matrix subject is coextensive with the speaker’s SOURCE of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT, or whether the matrix subject $\neq$ SOURCE.

³⁷The initial description of this interpretive effect referred to the interpretation of *bali* as a ‘hearsay’ reading, and described various interpretive effects that we now believe are inferences resulting from the underlying analysis we advance here (e.g., inferences that the reported information was unreliable, or that the referent of the matrix subject is themselves unreliable in the case of using *bali*). Because our discussion here is a large expansion of the relevant empirical contexts, we don’t overburden the reader with a re-evaluation of the previous discussions of *bali* vs. *AGR-li*, especially since the initial work on *AGR-li* simply reported interpretive distinctions (Diercks, 2010, 2013) and neither that work nor subsequent work has provided any analysis of these facts (Carstens, 2016; Diercks et al., 2020; Ke, 2023; Hanson, 2025).

- (90) a. Kayla heard that durian smells amazing.
 b. Kayla learned that durian smells amazing.
 c. Kayla discovered that durian smells amazing.

Notably, in such instances it is easier to construct possible scenarios where the speaker of (90) may have a source of the reported information that is distinct from the matrix subject. So if Kayla told the speaker “People were saying that durian smells amazing” and the speaker then utters (90a), Kayla is both the hearer and the sentence speaker’s SOURCE of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT. But there are instances where Kayla may not be the source of the reported information. If Kayla and the speaker are hiding outside an office and someone utters “durian smells amazing,” the speaker can utter (90a) and Kayla is not the SOURCE (because the speaker directly observed the event and can report what Kayla heard without Kayla having communicated any information to the speaker). English simply does not morphosyntactically track the SOURCE separately from matrix subjects, which is precisely what we argue that Lubukusu does explicitly via agreement on *-li* “say.”³⁸

It may seem like splitting hairs to get this precise about a speaker’s attribution of a source of reported information, which can vary both based on the real-world path of the information itself but also based on how the speaker accessed that content. But as we will see, this centrally plays into *AGR-li* in Lubukusu. And while it’s tempting to want to evaluate SOURCE arguments based on the actual origin of reported information (as opposed to the speaker’s attribution of their own source of information), what matters here is the speaker’s attribution. This is in fact the typical property of asserting the argument structure of a predicate. Take the CAUSE arguments of the two sentences in (91), for example.

- (91) a. Evolution formed humans.
 b. God formed humans.

Semantically and grammatically, it is equally acceptable to utter either of these sentences. By choosing between them the speaker clearly makes an attribution about the CAUSE of the forming, but this attribution can be made one way or another independent of actual human origins. What we are describing here for SOURCES is no different: extralinguistic context, matrix predicates, and speaker intention all play into what is most naturally attributed to be the SOURCE of COMMUNICATED CONTENT in any particular circumstance. Therefore, it is possible (and a typical property of human language) for a speaker to assign a SOURCE thematic role to an argument without the actual real-world origin of the communicated content being what is actually at issue.

5.2 Communication and attitude predicates

Communication predicates generally are able to take complements that are direct or indirect quotation. In the present context, this distinction is quite useful to clarify the role of *AGR-li*. In the case of direct quotation, the SOURCE of the direct quote is obligatorily the subject of the communication predicate. In the case of indirect quotation or propositional content, the subject of the communicative predicate is only optionally the reported SOURCE of the communicated content. What this predicts for present purposes is that direct quotation should require matching *AGR-li* (that matches the features of the matrix subject), while indirect quotation should be compatible with either *AGR-li* or *ba-li*.

Beginning with direct quotation (92), we find that the matrix-subject-agreeing *AGR-li* is obligatory, as predicted (*ali*, in this case). The non-agreeing *bali* is unacceptable with direct speech.

- (92) Wekesa a-yokel-a { a-li / *ba-li } “achichichichichi! N-ekhal-a lu-lw-aala.”
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-yell-FV 1SM-say / *2SM-say ouch 1SG-PST.cut-FV 1I-finger
 ‘Wekesa shouted, “Ouch! I cut my finger!”’

Turning to indirect speech, we see that both *AGR-li* and *ba-li* are permitted, with the expected interpretive contrast (93). When *AGR-li* is used in (93a), it indicates that the speaker is attributing the communicated content to

³⁸We should note that we are not committed to all clause-embedding predicates in English introducing a SOURCE syntactically, including those above. In English, we often do not see an overt “say” element in constructions describing communications. It is specifically “say” predicates which we claim obligatorily introduce a SOURCE argument. But the English discussion here helps clarify the relevant notions.

Wekesa, the subject of the matrix communication predicate. When *bali* is used in (93b), the speaker indicates that *Wekesa* uttered content, but is not necessarily the speaker's SOURCE for what the precise content was.

- (93) a. *Wekesa a-lom-a* a-li *ba-ba-ana ba-rekukh-a.*
 1*Wekesa* 1SM.PST-speak-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-leave-FV
 'Wekesa said that the children left.'
- b. *Wekesa a-lom-a* ba-li *ba-ba-ana ba-rekukh-a.*
 1*Wekesa* 1SM.PST-speak-FV 2SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-leave-FV
 'Wekesa said that the children left.'
- Paraphrase: 'Wekesa reportedly said that the children left.'*

Our analysis, which assumes the presence of a silent SOURCE, naturally accounts for this pattern. When the SOURCE of *AGR-li* and the matrix subject are co-indexed, we find what looks like agreement between the subject and *-li*. When the SOURCE argument is the third plural (noun class 2), we get a generic/impersonal, "they say..."-type reading. The "they say..."-type reading is unavailable with direct quotation because direct quotation is incompatible with this impersonal reading.

- (94) a. *A-li ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.*
 1SM-say 2-2-children 2SM-go-FV
 'S/he says that the children left.'
- b. *Ba-li ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.*
 2SM-say 2-2-children 2SM-go-FV
 'They say that the children left.' (akin to "It is said that the children left.")

So while [Diercks \(2013\)](#) previously treated *bali* in cases like this as a non-agreeing complementizer distinct from subject-agreeing *AGR-li*, on this approach we can treat them both as instances of *AGR-li*: one with an impersonal third person plural SOURCE (class 2 *bali*) and one with a SOURCE coreferent with the matrix subject (class 1 *ali* in the preceding examples).

Turning to attitude predicates, we find precisely the same pattern as with indirect quotation, where the choice is fully dependent on whether the speaker indicates that the attitude holder (i.e. the matrix subject) is the SOURCE of the reported information (*AGR-li*) or whether the attitude holder is *not* the SOURCE of the reported information (*bali*). An instance of this was shown in (88). But the choice of whether the subject-agreeing *AGR-li* is best, or the impersonal *bali* is best, is entirely based pragmatically on the speaker's source of the reported communicated content. We can see this in the examples below, where subject-agreeing *AGR-li* in (95) is compared with the generic *bali* in (96). When the speaker of the sentence has direct evidence arising from *Wekesa* (the referent of the matrix subject), subject-agreeing *AGR-li* is natural: these are instances where the matrix subject is the speaker's source for the reported information. The impersonal *bali* is available in the precise inverse circumstances in (96): *bali* is natural when the speaker's source of the communicated content is not the referent of the matrix subject, but some other entity or inference.

- (95) *Wekesa a-subil-a* a-li *ba-ba-ana ba-rekukh-a.*
 1*Wekesa* 1SM.PST-believe-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-leave-FV
 'Wekesa believes that the children left.'
- Proposed literal interpretation: 'Wekesa believes something, he says the children left.'
- a. # in this context: *The speaker knows that the children are in the back yard of the house and are not inside the house, so the house will be empty. From a distance he sees Wekesa arrive home and enter the house, and can't see anything else, but concludes that Wekesa will surely believe that the children have departed given their absence from the house.*
- b. ✓ in this context: *The speaker witnesses Wekesa start to do things he only does when the children aren't home: e.g. he's taken his pants off and is walking around in his underwear drinking beer.*
- c. ✓ in this context: *Wekesa doesn't like children. The speaker witnesses Wekesa's happy facial expression when he comes in the house and doesn't see the children around.*

d. ✓ in this context: *Wekesa told the speaker that he believes the children left.*

- (96) Wekesa a-subil-a ba-li ba-ba-ana ba-rekukh-a.
1Wekesa 1SM.PST-believe-FV 2-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-leave-FV

‘Wekesa believes that the children left.’ (hearsay reading)

- a. ✓ in this context: *The speaker knows that the children are in the back yard of the house and are not inside the house, so the house will be empty. From a distance he sees Wekesa arrive home and enter the house, and can’t see anything else, but concludes that Wekesa will surely believe that the children have departed given their absence from the house.*
- b. # in this context: *The speaker witnesses Wekesa start to do things he only does when he’s home alone: e.g. he’s taken his pants off and is walking around in his underwear drinking beer.*
- c. # in this context: *Wekesa doesn’t like children. The speaker witnesses Wekesa’s happy facial expression when he comes in the house and doesn’t see the children around.*
- d. # in this context: *Wekesa told the speaker that he believes the children left.*

The point here is that if we treat *AGR-li* as the abstract predicate *SAY* with an argument structure taking a *SOURCE* argument and a *COMMUNICATED CONTENT* argument, we have a natural explanation for the interpretive distinctions between *AGR-li* and impersonal *bali*: it comes down to who/what is the *SOURCE* of the *COMMUNICATED CONTENT*. Previous work had no account for these interpretive effects.

5.3 Communicative reception predicates

Communicative reception reports (e.g. *hear, read, learn*) are quite striking as it relates to the relationship between the matrix subject and the *SOURCE*. In related constructions, these predicates were shown to impact the behavior of indexical shift in Turkish (Ozyildiz et al., 2018) and the core source of mismatches in “say” complementation structures in Kipsigis (Driemel and Kouneli, 2025).

Recall that in a case like (97) that Alex’s status as the speaker’s *SOURCE* (or not) of the reported information is unspecified. (97) is compatible with a context where Alex is the one who told the speaker that someone told him (Alex) that Kayla left. In this scenario, Alex is both the hearer and the speaker’s *SOURCE* for the reported information. It is similarly possible that the speaker of (97) was a direct witness to Alex’s moment of perception, in which case the speaker’s *SOURCE* is whoever uttered the information to Alex (or the whole scenario itself), not Alex himself.

- (97) Alex heard that Kayla left.

The English sentence is naturally compatible with both scenarios, but makes no grammatical distinction between them. As we consider these types of contexts in Lubukusu, the distinction is tracked by agreement.

For at least some speakers, including our second author, agreement with a non-subject *SOURCE* is acceptable.³⁹ (98) is an instance of *-ulila* ‘hear,’ which overtly specifies the *SOURCE* of the information. In this instance, agreement with the information *SOURCE* (and *not* the matrix subject) is acceptable. In (98), the class 1 *ali* shares features with the class 1 source phrase in the matrix clause, and not with the first person singular (1sg) matrix subject.

- (98) N-a-ulil-a khu-Wekesa a- li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
1SG.SM-PST-hear-FV 17-1Wekesa 1-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV

‘I heard from Wekesa that the children left.’

³⁹This is in direct contrast with what was reported by Diercks (2010, 2013), where agreement with a non-subject source of reported information was documented as being ungrammatical. It’s not clear to us whether this difference from what is reported by Diercks (2013) is a genuine grammatical difference between the second author and the speakers reported previously, or if the pragmatic conditions were not set appropriately for the consultants at that point. If the latter (which is what we suspect), the previous unacceptability should have been marked as “#” instead of “*” (we understand the conditioning environments better now). For the most part, the second author’s judgments align with the patterns reported in Diercks (2013), so these are not obviously distinct grammars. We consider it likely that Diercks (2013) was not controlling for the pragmatic constraints in the way that we have here. Adding an overt source to the syntax is not sufficient, as speakers default to agreeing with matrix subjects nonetheless, because the *SOURCE* argument identifies the *speaker*’s source of the reported information, not an account of the real-life origin of the information.

Likewise, even an information source that is pragmatically accessible but not explicitly mentioned in the matrix clause can trigger agreement on *AGR-li*.

- (99) a. N-a-ulil-a o- li w-a-siim-a ka-ma-beele.
 1SG.SM-PST-hear-FV 2SG-SAY 2SG.SM-PST-like-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘I heard (you saying) that you like milk.’
 (source = addressee: context must make this clear for sentence to be acceptable)
- b. N-a-ulil-a a- li Wekesa a-a-siim-a ka-ma-beele.
 1SG.SM-PST-hear-FV 1-SAY 1Wekesa 1SM-PST-like-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘I heard (them (sg.) saying) that Wekesa likes milk.’
 (source = Wekesa: context must make this clear for sentence to be acceptable)

The pattern in (98)-(99) clearly aligns with the “say”-based approach put forth here, because the SOURCE is a syntactically projected argument of *-li* that controls agreement.

It is common for the “hearer” to also be the SOURCE for the speaker (if it was the referent of the subject of ‘hear’ who informed the speaker of the sentence about the hearing event). We thus readily see the configuration where the matrix subject and the SOURCE of *AGR-li* ‘say’ are identical, giving rise to what is treated as prototypical “complementizer agreement” as discussed in the literature.

- (100) Wekesa a-ulil-a a- li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-hear-FV 1-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV
 ‘Wekesa heard that the children left.’ (the speaker’s source for the reported information is Wekesa)

Crucially, *AGR-li* also is able to alternate with *bali*, as shown in (101), indicating that Wekesa is not the SOURCE, yet leaving the identity of the SOURCE unspecified (either due to ignorance or other interactional/sociolinguistic factors).

- (101) Wekesa a-ulil-a ba-li ba-ba-ana b-a-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-hear-FV 2SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV
 ‘Wekesa heard that the children left.’

Diercks (2010, 2013) reported that the mismatching agreement in (98) and (99) is not possible, but even for those speakers, *AGR-li* still alternated with *bali* and has the same interpretable effects, which we attribute to SOURCE-tracking.

- (102) Mosesi a-ul-ile { a-li / ba-li } Sammy k-eb-a chi-rupia.
 1Moses 1SM-hear-PFV 1SM-say / 2SM-say 1Sammy 1SM-PST.steal-FV 10-money
 ‘Moses heard that Sammy stole the money.’
 • If Moses does believe it: ✓ *bali*, ✓ *ali*
 • If Moses doesn’t believe it, or if the speaker doubts it: ✓ *bali* **ali*
 (Diercks, 2010, 290, glosses adjusted)

Diercks (2010) nonetheless claimed that agreement with overt non-subject sources was ungrammatical, due to examples like (103):

- (103) judgments reported from previous work, glosses adjusted
- Khw-a-ulile khukhwama khu-Sammy khu-li (*a-li) ba-limi ba-a-fun-a ka-ma-indi.
 1PL.SM-PST-hear from 17-1Sammy 1PL.SM-say (*1SM-say) 2-farmers 2SM-PST-harvest-FV 6-6-maize
 ‘We heard from Sammy that the farmers harvested the maize.’ (Diercks, 2010, 294, glosses adjusted)

While it's possible that the Bungoma-based consultants that Diercks worked with for that previous work have distinct grammars from that of the second author, our interpretation of examples like (103) is that subject-oriented *AGR-li* is largely conventional, and detailed pragmatic contexts are required to make non-subject-oriented *AGR-li* the natural option.⁴⁰ Lacking that pragmatic control, we suspect that those speakers defaulted to subject-agreeing *AGR-li*. On our account in this work, in a sentence like (103) the speaker asserting this information would naturally be claiming responsibility for the reported information (and attributing responsibility to Sammy would create a distancing effect, removing their own responsibility for the information): this might explain the previously-reported degraded judgments. We discuss the apparent subject bias of *AGR-li* in §5.7.

Prior analyses (Diercks, 2013; Carstens, 2016; Diercks et al., 2020) were designed to rule out agreement between *agr-li* and any DP other than the subject based on what was known at the time, but given the new facts our investigation has brought to light, this is not the state of affairs that the analysis must capture. With the SOURCE-based analysis, what determines the availability of mismatches (between *AGR-li* and matrix subjects) and why communicative reception reports are special comes to light – the speaker is able to report the “hearer” as SOURCE or not, depending on a variety of syntactic, semantic, and pragmatic factors.⁴¹

In cases like those in (104), the speaker can indicate that the referent of the matrix subject (Wekesa, here) is the speaker's source of the news that Wekesa heard/read/was told. It is also possible to indicate that Wekesa was not the source using *bali* or sometimes *kali* (agreeing with class 6 news), where the effect of *kali* similarly indicates that the subject is not the SOURCE.⁴²

- (104) a. Wekesa a-ulil-a ka-ma-keni { a-li / bali / ka-li } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1.SM.PST-hear-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa heard the news that the children left.’
 b. Wekesa a-som-a ka-ma-keni { a-li / bali / ?kali } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1.SM.PST-read-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa read the news that the children left.’
 c. Wekesa a-bool-el-w-a ka-ma-keni { a-li / bali / #ka-li } ba-ba-ana
 1Wekesa 1.SM.PST-spoke-APPL-PASS-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children
 ba-ch-a.
 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa was told the news that the children left.’

To demonstrate that it is in fact the content noun controlling agreement and not some type of expletive, we illustrate the same pattern for “rumor” below, which is from a distinct noun class.

- (105) N-a-ulil-a chi-mbolwa chi- li/#n-di w-a-siim-a ka-ma-beele.
 1SG.SM-PST-hear-FV 10-rumor 10-SAY/1SG.SM-SAY 2SG.SM-PST-like-FV 6-6-milk
 ‘I heard the rumor saying that you like milk.’

In this instance, the pragmatics of a first singular subject hearing a rumor makes it infelicitous for *AGR-li* to agree with the matrix subject; this would amount to the speaker attributed the content of the rumor to themselves when they are trying to report having *heard* something that is unconfirmed. Cases like these are somewhat the death knell for the previous accounts of Lubukusu *AGR-li*: far from *AGR-li* obligatorily agreeing with matrix subjects, it's not only that there are occasional exceptions, but we can construct circumstances where agreeing with the matrix subject is unacceptable.

⁴⁰For example, we suspect that the equivalent of (103) with a 2nd person singular subject and *ali* agreement on ‘say’ (as in (118) below) would be more acceptable to the Bungoma speakers from Diercks’ original work, as it wouldn’t involve the speaker potentially distancing themselves from the information they are reporting.

⁴¹For instance, when the subject is 1SG, the effect of a mismatch between 1SG and *bali* is stronger, because a stronger implicature is triggered when the speaker chooses not to report themselves as the source of the reported content.

⁴²We do not have a clear explanation for what makes *kali* more or less acceptable across cases; this will be an issue for future research.

5.4 Inanimate Sources

There exist examples with existentials where there is not an animate SOURCE at all, where agreement is between an inanimate noun and *AGR-li* or *bali*. In §6 we will discuss cases from English such as (106), where the only viable subject of “say” is “rumor:”

(106) There is a rumor saying that the children left.

A parallel situation can be constructed in Lubukusu, where there is a null expletive subject. In these cases, “rumor” becomes a viable controller of agreement, while *ba-li* also remains a viable option.

(107) Y-a-ba-o e-mbeo { bali / e-li } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.
 9SM-PST-be-16 9-rumor 2-SM-SAY / 9-SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘There was a rumor (saying) that the children left.’

Relatedly, (108) is a case where *AGR-li* modifies the subject, the nominal *embeo* ‘rumor,’ which is able to control agreement. The important point here is that it is possible for inanimate nouns be to be treated as the source when no other pragmatically-viable source is available.

(108) E-mbeo { e-li / bali } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a y-eenga khu-khol-a ba-n-chimy-e
 9-rumor 9-SM-SAY / 2-SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV 9SM-almost 15-make-FV 2SM-1SG.OM-stop-SUBJ
 ki-mi-limo.
 3-3-work
 ‘The news saying that the children left almost made it possible for them to fire me.’ (lit: stop me from working)

When the pragmatic/semantic context is such that the source of the rumour/news/etc. is the matrix subject, as is the case in (109), the subject must control agreement or *bali* must be used. Several representative cases are presented below.

- (109) a. Wekesa a-keesi-a ka-ma-keni { a-li / bali / #ka-li } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1.SM.PST-spread-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa spread the news that the children left.’
 b. Wekesa a-bool-a ka-ma-keni { a-li / bali / #ka-li } babaana bacha.
 1Wekesa 1.SM.PST-speak-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa spoke the news that the children left.’
 c. Wekesa a-subil-a kamakeni { a-li / bali / #ka-li } babaana bacha.
 1Wekesa 1.SM.PST-believe-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa believed the news that the children left.’
 d. Wekesa a-reeb-a khu-ma-keni { a-li / bali / #ka-li } babaana bacha.
 1Wekesa 1.SM.PST-ask-FV 17-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa asked about the news that the children left.’

The infelicity of *kali* is perhaps surprising, but we take it to be the result of a pragmatic constraint that strongly prefers the SOURCE to be animate when possible (see §5.7).⁴³

5.5 Subject ≠ SOURCE

By manipulating the predicate and communicated content in such a way that the matrix subject cannot reasonably be identified as the SOURCE or where such an interpretation would be strongly disfavored due to being unlikely in the real world, we should expect that it should be marked for the matrix subject to control agreement on *AGR-li*. This is precisely what we see in cases like (110), where *bali* is strongly favored.

⁴³We attempted to find evidence that there are syntactic differences that give rise to different agreement patterns (e.g. exploring whether *AGR-li* can merge as a modifier of the content noun or only of the matrix VP), but have failed to find any clear evidence.

- (110) Wekesa a-lom-a a-li se-li bu-ng’ali ka-ma-keni { #a-li / bali / #ka-li } ba-ba-ana
 1Wekesa 1SM-speak-FV 1SM-SAY NEG-be 14-truth 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children
 ba-ch-a.
 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa said that it is not true the news that the children left.’

In (110), it is highly unnatural for “Wekesa” to be the *SOURCE* of content that he also claimed to be untrue. This remains possible, which is why *ali* is marked as infelicitous as opposed to ungrammatical. As with (109), we do not have an explanation for why *kali* is dispreferred in this case.

The same kind of manipulation is applied to the cases in (111), where the same result obtains.

- (111) a. Wekesa a-lob-a ka-ma-keni { #a-li / bali / #ka-li } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-refuse-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa refused/denied the news that the children left.’
 b. Wekesa a-kaani-a ka-ma-keni { #ali / bali / #kali } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-refute-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa refuted the news that the children left.’
 c. Wekesa a-ying-an-a ka-ma-keni { #ali / bali / #kali } ba-ba-ana ba-ch-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-debate-RECP-FV 6-6-news 1SM-SAY / COMP / 6SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-go-FV
 ‘Wekesa debated the news that the children left.’

Although it is a bit surprising that *kali* is infelicitous in these cases, our account not only explains why it’s possible for mismatches in phi-features between the matrix subject and *AGR-li* but also when one should expect to find mismatches.

5.6 Additional overt subjects of embedded *AGR-li*

As we showed above in §3.4, it is possible for embedded *AGR-li* to have an overt subject that is distinct from the matrix subject: this is strong evidence for arguing that *AGR-li* has its own argument structure and introduces its own arguments. Because this pattern is so informative for our concerns, we offer a few additional examples of this pattern here.

- (112) a. Ba-ba-aana ba-a-ulil-a e-mbakha o-mw-ifwi a-li Wekesa o-mu-silu.
 2-2-children 2SM-PST-hear-FV 9-news 1-1-thief 1SM-say 1Wekesa 1-1-stupid
 ‘The people heard the news, the thief saying Wekesa is stupid.’
 b. Ba-b-ebusi ba-a-rekeresi-a e-mbakha o-mw-aana a-li a-kha-lekh-e ka-ma-somo.
 2-2-parents 2SM-PST-overhear-FV 9-news 1-1-child 1SM-say 1SM-FUT-leave-FUT 6-6-education
 ‘The parents overheard the news, the child saying that he’ll leave schooling.’

5.7 Why is there a matrix subject bias?

It is abundantly clear that the agreement morphology on *AGR-li* tracks the speaker’s source of the communicated content. We have implemented this observation via an analysis of *AGR-li* as a predicate with its own argument structure, and the subject of *AGR-li* is a *SOURCE* argument. This source may be coreferent with the matrix subject when *AGR-li* heads an embedded clause, but it is not necessarily coreferent with the matrix subject. That said, it was not merely accidental that the previous (and ultimately inaccurate) empirical claim was that *AGR-li* always agrees with the matrix subject. The previous work and our own observations confirm that—all other things being equal—there is in fact a strong matrix subject bias for the agreement on *AGR-li*.⁴⁴ That can be overridden with careful control of the pragmatic context, the matrix predicate, and the content of the *AGR-li* clauses, but given the precision necessary it is not surprising to us that the initial work did not identify these patterns.

⁴⁴Ideally this could be confirmed with experimental and/or psycholinguistic work or naturalistic corpus studies, but that goes beyond what we can do here.

So where does this matrix subject bias arise from? We suggest that there are three main interacting sources, which we discuss in turn here.

(113) Proposed explanations for *AGR-li* matrix subject bias

- Single event requirement
- Real-world likelihoods
- Grammar of subjecthood

5.7.1 Single-event requirement creates a matrix subject bias

First, as we discussed in §4.4.2, it appears that the kind of clausal adjunction that *AGR-li* utilizes is only possible when conceptualizing the adjunct clause as part of a single event with the matrix clause. This means any situation where there is a separate source from the matrix subject cannot be interpreted as a separate event, that is, the interpretation is not that X did something while Y said something. Instead, X doing something and Y saying something has to be able to be conceptualized as a single event. This of course highly constrains the predicates and contexts wherein the matrix subject and the *AGR-li* predicate could have different subjects. Communication reception predicates are perhaps the best suited for such things (X hears Y saying), but as we’ve seen, it is not necessarily restricted to those contexts.

So, the point is: is not impossible to describe a single event with two distinct subjects of distinct predicates (we provide a number of examples above). But it requires careful control of contexts, and otherwise it does seem quite natural that a single event will be described with a single agent or experiencer, which would then naturally also be interpreted as the source of the communicated content as well.

5.7.2 Real-world likelihoods constrain non-subject-agreeing *AGR-li*

Alongside that single event requirement, real-world likelihoods of the matrix predicate and *AGR-li* having different subjects also limit the contexts where we find this occurring. *AGR-li* canonically introduces an embedded clause containing information that has been communicated by some source. When a speaker uses a matrix attitude predicate alongside *AGR-li*, they are stating that person X has some attitude with respect to some communicated content. It is exceedingly natural in real-world contexts that the speaker of that sentence would have obtained the relevant information to assert that state of affairs from the communicator/attitude holder themselves (e.g. the attitude-holder told the speaker, or the speaker directly observed the attitude-holder). It is of course possible that the speaker would have learned of this in some indirect way (and hence we find *bali* constructions as well)), but it ought not be surprising that there is a tendency for speakers to report information about another person’s attitudes based on evidence that the speaker observed from that person themselves.

5.7.3 Grammatical considerations contribute to a matrix subject bias

Finally, it appears that *pro* arguments independently are biased towards a subject interpretation, which likewise adds a some weight towards a matrix subject interpretation. Generally, there is a bias towards interpreting subsequent *pro* arguments based on what argument is the subject of the sentence. A widespread property of pronominals crosslinguistically is that more salient/activated referents are most accessible for pronominal reference. Subjects are topical in Lubukusu (as in many languages), making them highly probable antecedents for a *pro* argument. This helps explain a persistent puzzle about passives and *AGR-li*. *AGR-li* can readily reference the φ -features of a matrix derived subject in a passive.

- (114) Sammy ka-bol-el-w-a a-li ba-keni b-ol-a.
 1Sammy 1SM-say-APPL-PASS-FV 1SM-SAY 2-guests 2SM-PST.arrive-FV
 ‘Sammy was told that the guests arrived.’ (Diercks, 2013, glosses adjusted)

Diercks (2010, 2013) reported that despite the ability to agree with derived subjects in passives, the inclusion of the agentive by-phrase disrupts the canonical agreement on *AGR-li* targeting the matrix subject.^{45,46}

⁴⁵Diercks (2010, 2013) documented a similar pattern for overt sources in verbs of receptive communication, where in the absence of fine-grained pragmatic control, speakers likewise found the presence of an overt source disruptive to *AGR-li* agreeing with the matrix subject.

⁴⁶The original work from Diercks showed use of *mbo* in context like these; the second author here doesn’t have an *mbo* element and instead

- (115) Nelsoni ka-a-bol-el-w-a nende ese { bali / *n-di / *a-li } ba-keni b-a-ach-a.
 1Nelson 1SM-PST-say-APPL-PASS-FV by me COMP *1SG.SM-SAY 1SM-SAY 2-guests 2SM-PST-go-FV
 ‘Nelson was told by me that the guests left.’ (Adapted from [Diercks, 2013](#), 380)

This apparent intervention effect had no explanation previously, but the proposed analysis of *AGR-li* introduced in this paper can largely account for these facts. But there is a key nuance: [Diercks \(2013\)](#) reported that passive by-phrases cannot trigger CA, and this is true for the second author of this paper as well:

- (116) ??N-a-bol-el-w-a ne-Wekesa a-li ba-ba-an-a b-a-ch-a.
 1SG.SM-PST-say-APPL-PASS-FV by-1Wekesa 1-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV
 ‘I was told by Wekesa that the children left.’

This is somewhat surprising, given our extensive demonstration that non-subject SOURCES readily trigger agreement on *AGR-li*. And in a non-passive parallel to (119), the agentive subject readily triggers agreement in *AGR-li*:

- (117) Wekesa a-a-m-bol-el-a a-li ba-ba-an-a b-a-ch-a.
 Wekesa 1SM-PST-1sgOM-say-APPL-PASS-FV 1-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV
 ‘Wekesa told me that the children left.’

One potential analysis of these effects previously reported by [Diercks \(2013\)](#) could be that with a first person subject, by using a form of *AGR-li* ‘say’ that is not first person, the speaker is distancing themselves from their own self-report, which could create pragmatic oddness. Adjusting this for a *hear* predicate is natural (cf. (103) above):

- (118) Mw-a-ulile khukhwama khu-Sammy {mu-li | a-li} ba-limi ba-a-fun-a ka-ma-indi.
 2PL.SM-PST-hear from 17-1Sammy 2PL.SM-say 1SM-say) 2-farmers 2SM-PST-harvest-FV 6-6-maize
 ‘You (PL) heard from Sammy that the farmers harvested the maize.’ (Adapted from [Diercks 2010](#): 294)

The same adjustment in the passive instance, however, doesn’t improve the naturalness of agreeing with the source argument when it is a by-phrase in a passive.

- (119) Mw-a-bol-el-w-a ne-Wekesa {mu-li | #a-li} ba-ba-an-a b-a-ch-a.
 2PL.SM-PST-say-APPL-PASS-FV by-1Wekesa 2PL-SAY 1-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-PST-leave-FV
 ‘You (PL) were told by Wekesa that the children left.’

So for some of the examples that were previously-reported by [Diercks \(2010, 2013\)](#) to be ungrammatical or unnatural, we have reported here that they are both grammatical and felicitous in appropriate contexts, such as *AGR-li* agreeing with a non-subject source argument (e.g. in examples like (118)). That said, *AGR-li* remains unnatural agreeing with a source when it is a by-phrase in a passive sentence even when adjusting the matrix derived subject of the passive to be even more pragmatically conducive (as a second plural subject).

So why can the overt source in a verb of hearing trigger agreement on *AGR-li*, but the by-phrase source of the reported information in a passive sentence cannot? We suggest that the issue here is in fact a familiar one regarding antecedence of pronominals. While pronominals can refer to any discourse referent (that does not trigger a binding violation), salient/activated referents are highly preferred, and potential referents of lower salience are less likely (e.g. [Cardinaletti and Starke, 1999](#)). Likewise, passivization is an operation that promotes a non-subject (and non-topic) to subject/topic position. We would suggest, then, that the main problem with *AGR-li* agreeing with the argument in the passive by-phrase in (119) is that the act of promoting the passivized subject and demoting the by-phrase agent makes the passive subject an aboutness topic, and of higher salience, and therefore the highly preferred antecedent to *pro*.

We can see this effect in play in instances that have nothing to do with *AGR-li*. Each example in (120) has two sentences, the second of which has a *pro* subject. In (120a) the initial sentence is active, and the subject *Nafula* uses *bali* here.

is readily interpreted as the antecedent of the *pro* subject in the second sentence. In (120b), in contrast, the first sentence is a passive (based off the active sentence in the first example); here, the judgments for the antecedent of the subsequent *pro* subject of the second clause are inverted. In this instance, the passivized subject *Nelsoni* is the preferred antecedent for *pro*.

- (120) a. Nafula a-p-a Nelsoni. Mala *pro* a-a-ch-a.
 1Nafula 1SM.PST-hit-FV 1Nelson Then 1SM-NAR-go-FV
 ‘Nafula hit Nelson. Then *pro* left.’
 * Nelson left.
 ✓ Nafula left.
- b. Nelsoni a-p-w-a ne Nafula. Mala *pro* a-a-ch-a.
 1Nelson 1SM.PST-hit-PASS-FV by 1Nafula Then 1SM-NAR-go-FV
 ‘Nelson was hit by Nafula. Then *pro* left.’
 ✓ Nelson left.
 * Nafula left.

Presumably, the discourse function of a passive sentence is what is at play here: by demoting a subject and promoting an object to the subject role in (120b), a speaker makes the derived subject the topic of discussion and therefore of higher salience than the by-phrase agent, which affects the preferred antecedent for the *pro* subject of the subsequent sentence. We take this as evidence that the dispreference for passive by-phrases to control agreement on *AGR-li* has to do with general principles of pronominal antecedence and not anything particular to the *AGR-li* construction.

Why this is relevant to our discussion in this section is that this appears to demonstrate yet another constraining factor on the target of *AGR-li* agreement. The topical/accessible nature of matrix subjects is going to highly bias the pragmatically neutral interpretation of a *pro* subject of *AGR-li*. That pragmatic neutrality can certainly be overcome, of course, but it does contribute to a matrix-subject bias of *AGR-li*.

5.8 Summary

In summary, we have highlighted cases where there are mismatches between the phi features of the matrix subject and those displayed on *AGR-li*. We have argued that *AGR-li* selects a SOURCE as its subject, which is often an empty category. Depending on the matrix predicate and particular properties of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT, the matrix subject may or may not be construed as viable as the speaker’s SOURCE of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT. When the matrix subject is the SOURCE, it appears to be standard phi-agreement. An alternative, *ba-li*, is almost always available (excluding direct quotation). Thus the difference between subject-agreeing *AGR-li* and impersonal *bali* boils down to what silent element is introduced as the SOURCE:⁴⁷

- (121) Wekesa_i a-lom-a *pro*_i (a-li) ba-ba-ana ba-rekukh-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-speak-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-leave-FV
 ‘Wekesa said that the children left.’
- (122) Wekesa_i a-lom-a *pro*_{CL.2} (ba-li) ba-ba-ana ba-rekukh-a.
 1Wekesa 1SM.PST-speak-FV 2SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM.PST-leave-FV
 ‘Wekesa said that the children left.’

If the speaker wishes to indicate that they attribute the SOURCE of the communicated content to be Wekesa, they do so by uttering (121). If the speaker does not know the identity of the SOURCE, wishes not to reveal the identity of the SOURCE, or similar, (122) is uttered. Our proposal captures these striking facts with a rather simple syntactic analysis that requires very little complicated machinery and opens the door to future research on the socio-cultural and discourse properties that give rise to different agreement patterns.⁴⁸

⁴⁷Reminder: class 2 in Bantu languages is the third person plural animate noun class.

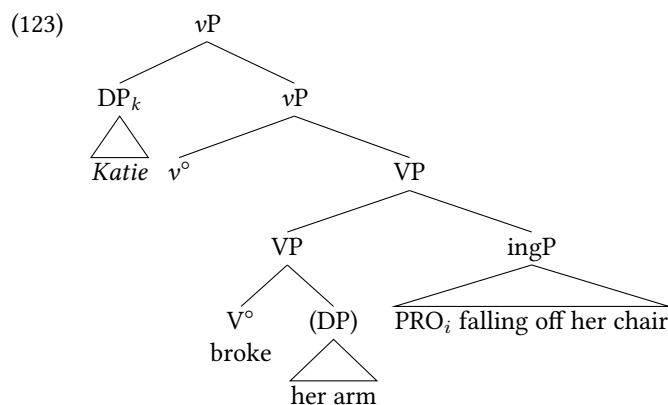
⁴⁸A reviewer wonders whether the subject of *AGR-li* can be an empty category even in main clause uses of *AGR-li*: this is readily available, as the examples below show.

6 ‘Say’ -ing constructions in English

Major (2021, 2024) argues that there is a relationship between converbial “say” clauses in Uyghur and English “say” + -ing clauses in English (see also Privoznov, 2022). In this paper we have argued that *AGR-li*, previously thought to be a complementizer, is well-analyzed as a verbal adjunct clause. We demonstrate here that “say” + -ing clauses in English show many of the exact same properties, which is notable because “say” in English being unambiguously a verbal element. Establishing the properties of these “say” + -ing clauses will also allow us to use them to address questions about a prominent alternative analysis and some potential critiques of our approach about selection in §7.

6.1 A baseline syntax for -ing constructions

We begin with -ing adjuncts without “say.”⁴⁹ The particulars of the -ing analysis do not really matter for present purposes, apart from the idea that they are adjuncts to the main clause (which seems fairly uncontroversial) (but see Truswell, 2011; Landau, 2021; Privoznov, 2022, a.o.). We assume the analysis in (123).



For present purposes, it suffices to point out that -ing adjuncts can encode a variety of different meanings (e.g. causation, manner, results, etc.) depending on where they merge and what they combine with. “Saying” clauses are no different than any other V + -ing combination, other than properties already discussed for “say” itself in the preceding sections.

6.2 Inanimate subjects of “saying” and SOURCES

English “say” + ing clauses also very clearly illustrate key aspects of our analysis of “say” as an abstract predicate: inanimate subjects of “say” readily appear in “say” + ing adjunct clauses. Throughout this section we illustrate with examples from the wild.

- (124) a. KFC has responded to **a widespread rumor saying** it offers free refills on its chicken buckets if you finish it within an hour.
(from <https://www.today.com/food/restaurants/kfc-bucket-refill-policy-free-chicken-rumor-rcna75326>)

- (1) a. Q: What does Wafula say?
A: *pro* A-li a-kha-khukenyi-e.
1_{pro} 1SM-say 1SM-FUT-visit-FUT
'he says (that) he'll visit us.'
b. Q: What does the letter say?
A: *pro* E-li ba-ba-ana khe-b-eech-a.
9_{pro} 9SM-say 2-2-children PROG-2SM-come-FV
'It says that the children are coming.'

⁴⁹These configurations are generally taken to be control configurations (for an overview, see Landau, 2021), though alternative analyses are available (McFadden and Sundaresan, 2018).

- b. On May 3, there was **news saying** that actor Sarathbabu passed away, but his sister had confirmed to TNM that this wasn't the case.
(from <https://www.thenewsminute.com/flix/divya-spandana-slams-irresponsible-reports-that-claimed-she-died>)
- c. But all the talk is about Indiana Fever rookie Caitlin Clark, with **rumors saying** that Unrivaled might offer her a \$1 million salary and even equity in the league if she joins.
<https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/sports/2000/03/17/indiana-program-responds-to-former-players-charges/7aa6407b-d48d-414f-a819-a79c3caced0b/>

Notice in (124a) that the only natural reading is one in which the matrix subject (KFC) is not interpreted as the subject of “saying.” The reason for this is that KFC refutes the content of the rumor, suggesting that the attributed SOURCE of the rumor is not KFC.

6.3 The relationship between matrix subject and SOURCE of “saying”

It is often the case that the SOURCE of “saying” is identified as the matrix subject, as is likewise true for Lubukusu *AGR-li*. But much like for *AGR-li*, in English this is also dependent on a variety of factors. The first has to do with properties of the matrix predicate (or entire matrix VP in some cases). Beginning with attitude verbs (admittedly a bit marked in English), they strongly favor co-reference between matrix subject and SOURCE, as demonstrated by the cases in (125). In all of these examples we simply identify the subject of the “say”+*ing* adjunct clauses as EC (empty category), abstracting away from the particular analysis of the EC, which is tangential to our current concerns.

- (125) a. It looks as if Edward_i is thinking to himself, EC_i saying, “Dang girl, you really stink.”
(<https://www.hercampus.com/school/mcmaster/best-moments-in-twilight/>)
- b. It helps to have a Pro Bowl quarterback like Burrow and Gesicki_i knows it, EC_i saying he has “never been in the huddle with that kind of talent.”
(<https://www.palmbeachpost.com/story/sports/nfl/2024/04/10/mike-gesicki-was-not-slighting-tua-tagovailoa-with-talent-quote-miami-dolphins-cincinnati-bengals/73275010007/>)
- c. One fan_i couldn't believe it, EC_i saying, “lol wait...this whole time?”
(<https://www.eonline.com/news/1408366/how-to-pronounce-ava-phillippe-and-ryan-phillippes-last-name>)

There is a similarly strong subject-bias for communication predicates and manner of speech predicates (126).

- (126) a. Miller said the caller_i, who authorities referred to as Jane Doe to protect her privacy, spoke through whispers, EC_i saying she was being held captive at a house near a laundromat and her captor was asleep at her side.
(<https://abc7.com/post/killer-confession-detective-kim-mager-details-33-hour-interrogation-get-ohio-murderer/15573820/>)
- b. At the news conference, [the captain of the submarine]_i went into a weird whisper, EC_i saying that he wouldn't get out of the race unless his team “came back and said, ‘There's no way you can win.’”
(<https://www.nytimes.com/2024/07/13/opinion/biden-president-age-time.html>)
- c. Meanwhile at the taxi rank, drivers_i shouted to us EC_i saying that business has been dead.
(<https://www.walesonline.co.uk/whats-on/whats-on-news/pontypridd-lockdown-rhondda-cynon-taf-18962363>)

This bias can be neutralized by considering another set of matrix VPs. For instance, recall from the end of Section 5.1, that there are clear cases where a mismatch between subject and SOURCE is strongly preferred. This is especially common for predicates like *respond/reject/denied/disregard*, as demonstrated below:

- (127) a. KFC has responded to a widespread rumor_i EC_i saying that it offers free refills on its chicken buckets.
- b. TV personality Joey de Leon has denied allegations_i EC_i saying that he was mocking rival TV host, Vice Ganda, in his previous Twitter post.
(<https://malaysia.news.yahoo.com/joey-leon-denies-mocking-vice-091600013.html>)
- c. Those close to the rapper released a statement announcing his death, a couple of hours after his manager denied rumors_i EC_i saying he was disconnected from life support.

One set of predicates that is highly variable with respect to whether the SOURCE of “say” is co-referenced with the matrix subject are communicative reception verbs (e.g. “hear” and “learn”). In the examples in (128) the subject of the communicative reception predicate is interpreted as the experiencer, but is clearly not the SOURCE of the COMMUNICATED CONTENT for the *saying*-clause.

- (128) a. “We heard a rumor_i EC_i saying it was Trent,” Ericka said.
(<https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/sports/2000/03/17/indiana-program-responds-to-former-players-charges/7aa6407b-d48d-414f-a819-a79c3caced0b/>)
- b. During an appearance on ‘Challenge,’ alum Zach Nichols’ podcast, Kyle was asked about rumors_i EC_i saying that his past tumultuous relationship with ‘The Challenge’ star Cara Maria Sorbello led to him being banned from the show.
(<https://www.theashleysrealityroundup.com/2024/10/01/kyle-christie-refutes-rumors-of-being-blacklisted-from-the-challenge/>)

However, in cases like the following, the subject is also identified as the SOURCE:

- (129) a. Megan Sledge_i, a South Albany senior, had heard the rumors, EC_i saying, ‘I kind of just didn’t want to believe anything so I kept everything out of my mind and just didn’t think about them’
(<https://www.dailymail.co.uk/news/article-2268924/School-librarian-52-sentenced-years-prison-having-sex-student-17-car-sexting-teens.html>)
- b. Lisa Anne-Morris, mother of Ben Morris who was 20 years old when he died, described the moment she_i was told the news, EC_i saying “a part of me died with him”.
(<https://www.standard.co.uk/news/health/mental-health-trust-essex-fined-patient-deaths-b941038.html>)

The main take-home message is that the SOURCE of these “say”+*-ing* clauses may certainly be coreferent with the matrix subject, and in many instances displays a strong bias to be interpreted that way. But with careful control of pragmatic context and the matrix verb phrase properties (predicate and object) along with the saying-clause content, at times the bias can be switched, such that the construction strongly favors a mismatch between the SOURCE of “say”+*-ing* and the matrix subject.

7 Addressing some alternative analyses and critiques

There are a range of alternative analyses for the range of new facts that we’ve reported in this paper.⁵⁰

- (130) Alternative analyses for Lubukusu *AGR-li*:
- *AGR-li* is a complementizer with uSource features.
 - *AGR-li* is a complementizer with its own argument structure
 - *AGR-li* is a verb, but heads a VP that is itself the complement of the matrix predicate.

We comment briefly on the first two here, while devoting a more extended discussion to the third. First, a reviewer suggests that an agreeing complementizer analysis could be maintained if the φ -probe on the agreeing complementizer was specified to search for a source feature (the reviewer specifically suggests an analysis where the relevant features are interpretable, but unvalued, and therefore need to be valued in the course of the derivation: see Rooryck and Vanden Wyngaerd 2011 for similar claims re: feature valuation in anaphoric contexts). There are a number of reasons that this analysis is doubtful for *AGR-li*. First, the use of *AGR-li* as a main clause predicate seems to push back against the complementizer analysis of *AGR-li*. Second, discourse participants seem to be available as the valuers of the features on *AGR-li*; such an analysis requires (on all theories of Agree that we are aware of) a Goal DP present in the syntax, and it’s not clear where that DP would be present in the syntax without an analysis of there being a null argument of some predicate somewhere overtly in the syntax to serve as a Goal for Agree. Another empirical argument against this is the evidence we discussed in (32) and (33), where *AGR-li* has an overt subject, even in embedded contexts. All of this suggests that *AGR-li* is a predicate that introduces argument. A second alternative

⁵⁰Our gratitude to our anonymous reviewers for raising these.

along these lines, of course, is that *AGR-li* is a complementizer that introduces arguments: a clausal subordinator that shares some verbal properties. In our view, this is not much different than the claim we advance here (and on a Minimalist view that categories themselves are emergent, the distinction might be trivial). But again, the main-clause uses of *AGR-li* are perhaps suggestive that a complementizer analysis is dispreferred, though there could be analytical ways around that critique.

As to the third alternative analysis, a major data point that reviewers raise is that *AGR-li* clauses are able to head subjunctive clauses that appear to be selected by the matrix predicate.

- (131) Watulo eny-a (a-li) ba-ba-ana ba-ch-e.
 1Watulo 1SM.want-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Watulo wants the children to go.’

The matching of a subjunctive embedded clause to a desiderative matrix predicate is typical complement clause behavior, and raises questions about both the verbal analysis of *AGR-li* and the adjunct analysis of *AGR-li* clauses. We address these in turn in the sections that follow.

7.1 *AGR-li* vs *bali* in *want*-complements

First, we want to note that despite appearing in a context where we certainly do expect complement clauses to appear, *AGR-li* nonetheless retains the same interpretive properties that we have shown are readily explainable based on the argument structure of *AGR-li* as a “say” predicate. So first, note that these subjunctive contexts retain the *AGR-li* vs. *bali* distinction discussed above.

- (132) Wekesa eny-a a-li/ba-li e-fula e-w-e.
 1Wekesa 1SM.want-FV 1SM-SAY/2SM-SAY 9-rain 9SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Wekesa wants the rain to go away.’

The subjunctive complement of a *want*-predicate seems an unlikely candidate for say-complementation on the face of it, since no communication need be involved in this instance: this seems much more likely to be an instance of a true complement clause. But in fact, using *AGR-li* in a sentence like (132) does presuppose some kind of COMMUNICATED CONTENT originating from Wekesa: otherwise, how can the speaker report Wekesa’s desire? So consider the *AGR-li*-complementation with *-enya* ‘want’ (133), and the contexts listed below.

- (133) Wekesa eny-a a-li e-fula e-w-e.
 1Wekesa 1SM.want-FV 1SM-SAY 9-rain 9SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Wekesa wants the rain to go away.’
- # in this context: *Wekesa is holding a big outdoor party this evening and so if the rain kept going all evening it would clearly be a problem. But the speaker has not seen or talked to Wekesa and doesn’t even know Wekesa personally*
 - ✓ in this context: *The speaker witnesses Wekesa whine and complain when it starts raining*
 - ✓ in this context: *The speaker witnesses Wekesa’s facial expression watching the rain*
 - ✓ in this context: *Wekesa told the speaker that he wants the rain to go away*
- (134) Wekesa eny-a ba-li e-fula e-w-e.
 1Wekesa 1SM.want-FV 2SM-say 9-rain 9SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Wekesa wants the rain to go away.’
- ✓ in this context: *Wekesa is holding a big outdoor party this evening and so if the rain kept going all evening it would clearly be a problem. But the speaker has not seen or talked to Wekesa and doesn’t even know Wekesa personally*
 - # in this context: *The speaker witnesses Wekesa whine and complain when it starts raining*
 - # in this context: *The speaker witnesses Wekesa’s facial expression watching the rain*

- d. # in this context: *Wekesa told the speaker that he wants the rain to go away*

In cases where evidence is lacking directly from Wekesa, *bali*-complementation is the more natural option. In contexts where Wekesa has communicated this content to the speaker (via overt speech, or implicitly through speaker’s inference by means of facial expressions, emotional outbursts, etc), subject-agreeing *AGR-li* is more natural.

This suggests, then, that even in apparent subjunctive complement clauses of ECM-type predicates like *-enya* ‘want,’ we see key differences between impersonal *bali* and subject-oriented *AGR-li*, and *AGR-li* continues to behave like a “say” predicate, necessitating COMMUNICATED CONTENT with a SOURCE and not simply being an instance of a complementizer heading an embedded clause. Informally speaking, this would mean that a *want* predicate with an *AGR-li* clause would have a meaning something like what is shown in (135).

- (135) Wekesa eny-a a-li e-fula e-w-e.
1Wekesa 1SM.want-FV 1SM-SAY 9-rain 9SM-go-SUBJ

Proposed meaning: ‘Wekesa wants something, he communicated that the thing he wants is for the the rain to go away.’

7.2 Compatibility instead of selection

What a verbal analysis doesn’t explain, however, is why the matrix predicate in (135) and elsewhere seems to determine the Force specification of the clause that is selected by *AGR-li*. For a verbal analysis of *say* complementation where *say*-clause is the complement of the matrix predicate, such as Koopman (1984) and Driemel and Kouneli (2025), it is argued that predicates select for a complement with particular Mood or Force specifications (e.g. interrogative or subjunctive). Based on our proposal, this relationship is between the matrix VP and the clause embedded under *-li*, which we take to be an adjunct. As two anonymous reviewers point out, this requires an explanation. We introduce discussion here from AUTHORS (in prep), which mitigates these concerns by showing that the same configuration exists in English, where we suggest a notion like *compatibility* (Grimshaw, 2018) is more suitable than (s-)selection.

Recall in (132) that *want* combines with a subjunctive clause. Rogative verbs like *ask* requires that nominals and/or clauses it combines with be interrogative. Speech verbs (e.g. *-lom-*) are compatible with declaratives, questions, subjunctives, or imperatives. An example with *ask* is provided in (136).

- (136) Wekesa a-a-reeb-a (li-reeba) a-li Nafula acha wae(ena)?
1Wekesa 1SM-PST-ask-FV 5-question 1SM-SAY 1Nafula 1SM.PST-go-FV where
‘Wekesa asked (a question) saying, “Where did Nafula go?”’

A predicate like *ask* is often thought to s-select for an interrogative complement (Grimshaw, 1979) and c-select for a wider range of complement types.⁵¹ Grimshaw (2018) suggests that we do away with s-selection altogether, requiring instead a relationship of Force Compatibility, which is enforced by locally in her analysis. In (137), *question*, concealed questions and indefinites like *something* are all compatible with *ask*, although one likely wouldn’t want to say that *something* is inherently specified with interrogative Force. The nominal *an order* is specified for Force and is not interrogative, and is thus incompatible with *ask*, making it ungrammatical.

- (137) Wekesa asked {*a question* | *the price of sugar* | *something* | **an order*}.

Given that in the present paper, we liken *-li* clauses to English *saying* clauses, it is valuable to think about the relationship between the matrix predicate, *say*, and the complement of *say*. Given that *saying* modifies the matrix VP, when that VP contains a predicate like *ask*, the complement of *saying* obligatorily has Q-Force.

- (138) Wekesa asked {*a question* | *the price of sugar* | *something*}, saying, {“*How much is sugar?*” | #*Get me sugar!* | #*that sugar is expensive*}

⁵¹Pesetsky (1982) suggests that predicates vary with respect to whether they can assign case (e.g. license a DP complement) and their s-selectional properties (eliminating c-selection). It does not seem outside the realm of possibility that one could account for these facts with Pesetsky’s system.

This is important, because the same semantic restrictions on the complement of *ask* apply to the complement of *say*, which is embedded within an *-ing* adjunct clause, which is clearly non-local and clearly not selected by the matrix predicate. One may be tempted to make this relationship local via feature percolation through *say* into the left periphery of the adjunct clause, but the same dependency can be established across several sentences (139). Notice that when the matrix VP is headed by *ask*, it can be modified by a *saying* adjunct clause, which requires a question, but does not require that the question be in the first sentence following *saying* (139a). The same is shown for an order in (139b).

- (139) a. Steve asked him a question, saying, “We’ve been friends for years. We have been through a lot together. If you don’t trust me now, #(what could possibly change your mind in the future?)”
 b. Steve gave him an order, saying, “We’ve been friends for years. We have been through a lot together. #(Now get out of here!)”

Our conclusion from these facts is that predicates can impose compatibility requirements with respect to Force-containing XPs that can be applied non-locally. Based on our analysis that *-li* clauses are essentially *saying* clauses, we take the process that determines Force compatibility to be (roughly) the same in both *-li* and *saying* clauses. We take the same to be true for orders/imperatives as in (139b).

One reviewer references subjunctive-selecting predicates like *want* as their biggest concern for the *say*-based analysis of *-li* clauses as adjunct clauses. We suggest that the subjunctive selection should be treated using the same semantic compatibility mechanism required for interrogatives above. First it is worth noting that subjunctives in Lubukusu are not like their Romance counterparts. Just as *-li* embeds root interrogatives, root subjunctives (without a complementizer) are acceptable in Lubukusu with an optative or jussive interpretation (140).

- (140) Ba-ba-ana ba-ch-e.
 2-2-children 2SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Let/may the children leave.’

Now applying the argumentation of this paper to a case where the same subjunctive clause is embedded under *want*, as in (131), we end up with a literal translation that is roughly *Watulo wants it/something, saying, ‘Let/may the children leave.’* The most natural way of interpreting this *say* clause as a modifier is as specificational (i.e. what the desire is). Although we admit this is a bit clunky in English, we do not find it shocking that this structure would be translationally equivalent to the English *Watulo wants the children to leave*. It should be further noted that *want* is among the only predicates that can combine with a bare subjunctive clause or a subjunctive *AGR-li* clause. If *AGR-li* were a simple complementizer, there would be no reason to expect a difference between these clauses – this is an option that is an alternation that does not exist in Romance. On the contrary, however, there are interpretive differences between the two sentences.

- (141) a. Watulo eny-a ba-ba-ana ba-ch-e.
 1Watulo 1SM.want-FV 2-2-children 2SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Watulo wants the children to go.’
 b. Watulo eny-a a-li ba-ba-ana ba-ch-e.
 1Watulo 1SM.want-FV 1SM-SAY 2-2-children 2SM-go-SUBJ
 ‘Watulo wants the children to go.’

In the case without *AGR-li* (141a), it is interpreted such that Watulo is commanding that the children leave, where there will likely be punishment if the children remain. In the latter case with *AGR-li* (141b), the interpretation is that *Watulo* has indicated that he would like for the children to leave, but this does not carry the force of a command. We set aside the compositional semantic details that are necessary to account for this contrast, but the existence of such a contrast is much more compatible with an analysis where *AGR-li* corresponds to a lexical verb that contributes its own semantics.

7.3 On reportative evidentials

Cross-linguistically, there is a clear relationship between *say-complementation* and reportative evidentiality that requires some discussion. *AGR-li* carries many of the hallmarks of reported evidentials, such as perspective-shifting (AnderBois, 2014), which is encoded by agreement, and a more fine-grained decomposition of discourse roles (Faller, 2019), perhaps using Goffman (1979)’s animator (the person who is talking), principal (the person whose commitment is being described), and addressee. Pancheva and Rudin (2019) is such an analysis, which associates reportative evidentials with the features [+ANIMATOR, -PRINCIPAL]. In other words, the reportative evidential is responsible for indicating that the speaker is responsible for uttering the words, but the words do not describe the speaker’s own commitments. It also introduces a presupposition that there was a communicative event (presumably where the principal of the target sentence was the animator) on which the report is based. This is strikingly similar to our claims about *AGR-li*, as suggested by an anonymous reviewer and Paul Portner (p.c.). There are several factors worth considering in this light.

The first and most straightforward issue is best framed with respect to cases where *AGR-li* is the only overt predicate in the matrix clause. First, *AGR-li* introduces an overt subject in these cases, which is not generally (or ever?) a property of reportative evidentials. This same logic also applies to the contexts where *AGR-li* is not the matrix verb, yet still allows an overt subject, and (if the present analysis is on the right track) all *AGR-li* contexts. If we infer from this that *AGR-li* is a reportative evidential that takes an overt subject, the question becomes what differentiates the reportative evidential from a verb. With this assumption, reportative evidentials and communication/attitude verbs are all elements that relate some content (or quotation) to an agent/attitude holder/source (=principal?).

Once this step is taken, the only meaningful distinction between a reportative evidential analysis and a verbal analysis would be the lexical semantics of *-li*. If this is the central difference, then we do not see a clear path towards differentiating between lexical verbs, light verbs, bleached/defective verbs, and reportative evidentials. Turning back to what we have been calling stative ‘say’ in English, we have a verb that relates some content with a source. The lexical semantics of stative ‘say’ do not denote a present tense ‘speaking’ activity, but something closer to introducing a presupposition that there was a communicative act, where ‘Paul’ was the animator, and the content was that ‘we should discuss reportative evidentiality’. This is almost exactly the definition of a reportative evidential.

(142) Paul says we should discuss reportative evidentiality.

As a reviewer notes, we do use the language of evidentiality throughout this paper, but this is largely because of the functional similarities between stative ‘say’ across contexts and the function of evidentials.⁵²

8 Conclusions

In this paper we have argued that *AGR-li* in Lubukusu is not a C head of a CP complement clause, *contra* the previous approaches (Diercks, 2010, 2013; Carstens, 2016; Diercks et al., 2020; Ke, 2023; Hanson, 2025). In that previous work, the apparently-exceptional agreement properties (agreeing with the matrix subject) were the problematic and theoretically-interesting aspects of the construction. In contrast, the proposal here is that *AGR-li* is in fact a defective verbal element that has its own argument structure (a SOURCE and COMMUNICATED CONTENT) and is incorporated into clauses via adjunction (when it is not itself used as a matrix predicate). In the course of arguing for this conclusion we introduce a broad range of new empirical patterns of *AGR-li*, making the case that *AGR-li* clauses are not selected by matrix predicates, instead showing the syntactic and interpretive properties of verbal elements.

On this new approach, Lubukusu fits into a broader typology of *say-complementation*. A broad variety of recent research (and some older research) is showing that *say-complementation* often has verbal properties across a broad variety of language families: Bantu (Güldemann, 2008; Halpert, 2019; Kawasha, 2007; Letsholo and Safir, 2019); Nilo-Saharan (Driemel and Kouneli, 2025); Kwa (Kinyalolo, 1993; Koopman, 1984; Koopman and Sportiche, 1989; Major and Torrence, 2020); Turkic (Baker and Vinokurova, 2010; Major, 2022, 2021, 2024; Ozyildiz, 2017; Predolac,

⁵²One other reason to avoid referring to *AGR-li* as a reportative evidential comes from the typology of ‘say’ elements. Turkic ‘say’ elements have strikingly similar properties to *AGR-li*, but more importantly, Turkic languages also have dedicated reportative evidentials (see e.g. Sener, 2011; Korotkova, 2016). Crucially, ‘say’ elements embed reportative evidentials. If *AGR-li* is a rough equivalent to Turkic ‘say’, this is at least reason to think that the two types of elements should be treated separately. However, the precise relationship between ‘say’ and evidentiality is both underexplored and a fruitful domain for future research.

2017); Mongolic (Knyazev, 2015; Bondarenko, 2020); Semitic (Spadine, 2020); Sinitic (Chappell, 2008); Dravidian and Indo-Aryan (Balusu, 2020; Bayer, 1999); Englishes like AAVE (Martin and Wolfram, 1998), Nigerian Pidgin (Mfon Udoinyang, pc), and colloquial American English (Major, 2021). It is clear, however, that there are interesting differences between the extent of the verbal properties that are allowed on the “say” predicates in these “say”-complementation structures: Ikalanga (Letsholo and Safir, 2019), Kipsigis (Diercks and Rao, 2019; Diercks et al., 2020; Driemel and Kouneli, 2025), and Lubukusu make an interesting comparison set in this regard. Ikalanga shows many properties similar to Lubukusu, but also shows some degree of voice morphology on the “say”-based “complementizer.” Meanwhile, Kipsigis even allows object agreement on “say” in its complementizer-like usage. Clarifying the say-complementation structures cross-linguistically will open doors to exploring how/why these constructions vary cross-linguistically.

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This project grew out of independent observations by the first and second authors. Sikuku recognized a range of additional facts unaccounted for by Diercks’ previous work on the issue, which Diercks and Sikuku explored without a solidified analysis. Major independently speculated that Lubukusu “complementizer agreement” might be analyze-able under a verbal analysis of say-based “complementizers,” and brought that hypothesis to Sikuku and Diercks: this project is the result of that initial inquiry. This project was originally in development alongside Major’s dissertation, so though Lubukusu is not addressed in the dissertation this Lubukusu investigation contributed to Major’s thinking in that work. Long pandemic-related and life-related delays led to this paper being delayed long past that dissertation work. All data here reflect the intuitions of Sikuku, and Sikuku was the first to notice a range of patterns that did not fit Diercks’ previous proposals. Major, Sikuku, and Diercks jointly discussed data patterns and the appropriate empirical analysis of the Lubukusu constructions. Major brought the original novel analytical insights to the project, though these developed extensively through mutual work on the analysis. All three authors confirmed and refined the analysis for Lubukusu. Major and Diercks took the majority of the responsibility for putting the result into written form.

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